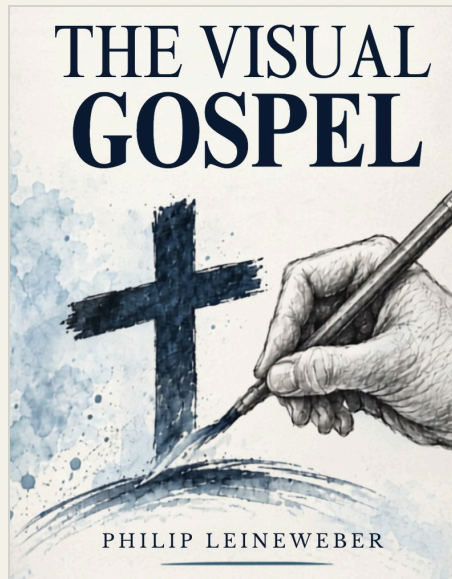


PHILIP LEINEWEBER



The Visual Gospel

Leader Guide

A 30-week study for small groups, classes, youth, and families. To be used alongside the devotional and the flashcard app — not instead of them.



Purchase the devotional

visualgospelbook.com

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About this guide

The Visual Gospel Leader Guide is a free companion to The Visual Gospel by Philip Leineweber (ISBN 979-8-1943079-3-7). Definitions and memory verses are taken from the book. The icebreakers, passages, and discussion questions were written for the gathering. They are not the reflection questions, gospel responses, or prayers printed in the devotion. Those belong to the personal reading. Each week ends by sending the group to someone far from Jesus, with one action and one true sentence.

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The drawings are the studies created for The Visual Gospel. Week numbers follow the book.

How to lead the hour

Plan on 60 to 75 minutes. The book is a 30-day devotion. This guide is 30 gatherings — one word a week. Your people should already have read that day. If they have not, still use this guide. Do not switch back to the journal prompts. Those were for personal reading. This hour is for opening the Bible together and then going to someone who does not know Christ.

The shape of a strong hour

Open the Bible and ask what it says before anyone explains what they feel. The text teaches. Then ask what we must believe, obey, and tell. Christ stays at the center. Application does not outrun Him. The reading is already done. This hour is a new passage, a clear conversation, and a sending.

1 · 7 MIN

Icebreaker

A light question tied to the picture. People may pass.

2 · 8 MIN

The word

Look at the drawing, read the definition, say the memory verse, open the card.

3 · 15 MIN

Open the Bible

A passage they did not already journal. Read it aloud. Ask what it says.

4 · 20 MIN

Around the room

Three new questions. Stay curious. Do not reteach the devotion.

5 · 5 MIN

Say it

Two volunteers put the word into one sentence a friend could understand.

6 · 5 MIN

Go

Name someone far from Jesus. Give the week's challenge: one action, and one true sentence.

7 · 8 MIN

Pray

Three prayers from the text, and the person just named. Leave room for others to pray out loud.

Before you walk in

- Read the day in The Visual Gospel yourself. Do not summarize the essay back to people who read it.
- Read the gathering's passage in your own Bible. The excerpt in the guide is a backup, not a replacement.
- Skim "Before you stumble." The hard weeks — wrath, depravity, propitiation, election — have a line you can say without starting a debate.
- Have the drawing ready: the book, a printed page, or a screen. Have Bibles in the room. Phones are for the card, then they go down.

How to ask

Ask the question, then wait long enough for someone besides you to answer. When an answer is fuzzy, ask "Where do you see that in the passage?" Do not give a speech. If someone repeats the journal question from the book, thank them and come back to the question in front of you. You are not the teacher of a new idea. The text is. Correct a wrong reading of the verse. Do it kindly, and do it.

Questions marked **Core** are the ones to keep if you only have 45 minutes: one voice on the icebreaker, the verse said together, the passage read aloud, the Core questions, the missional challenge, and a short prayer.

The picture and the cards

Show the drawing. Then use the short script under the picture if you need words. After that, open cards.visualgospelbook.com, find the week's word, and say the word, the definition, and the verse together once. The slide deck linked at the top of the lesson puts the drawing and definition on the first slide, the memory verse large on the

second, then one slide for each movement. Review two older cards if you are past week four and the room is willing. Then close it.

Students, families, and a shorter night

With students, use the icebreaker, the picture, the verse, the missional challenge, and the line marked for youth in the leader notes. Drop the second “from the passage” question if attention drops. At a family table, read the passage, ask one Core question, name one person far from Jesus, and pray the first prompt. You do not need every movement for the Word to do its work.

A note on the hard words

Wrath is not God losing His temper. Depravity means we cannot save ourselves, not that every person is as bad as possible or that their sadness is spiritual death.

Propitiation means wrath landed on Christ, and it is received by faith — do not tell a room that everyone is already safe, and do not shrink the cross to your circle.

Justification is a declaration, not the slow work of sanctification. Election, in week 30, is taught after the welcome of Christ is clear: whoever comes to Him, He will never cast out. The leader notes say this again where it matters. Read them. Do not read them aloud.

Thirty weeks

PART I · GOD'S HEART

1	Creation	Genesis 1:26–27
2	Love	John 3:16
3	Mercy	1 Peter 1:3
4	Grace	Ephesians 2:8–9

PART II · OUR PROBLEM

5	Sin	Romans 3:23
6	Depravity	Ephesians 2:1–2
7	Wrath	Romans 1:18
8	Judgment	Hebrews 9:27
9	Condemnation	John 3:18

PART III · CHRIST'S WORK

10	Incarnation	John 1:14
11	Gospel	Luke 2:10–11
12	Salvation	Romans 1:16
13	Atonement	1 Peter 2:24
14	Propitiation	1 John 2:2
15	Justification	Romans 3:24
16	Mediation	1 Timothy 2:5–6
17	Redemption	Ephesians 1:7
18	Reconciliation	Colossians 1:19–20
19	Forgiveness	Colossians 1:14

20	Covenant	Hebrews 9:15
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PART IV · THE SPIRIT'S ROLE

21	Regeneration	Titus 3:5
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22	Sealing	Ephesians 1:13
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23	Adoption	Ephesians 1:4–5
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24	Rescue	Colossians 1:13
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25	Faith	Romans 5:1
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26	Repentance	Mark 1:15
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27	Sanctification	1 Corinthians 6:11
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PART V · OUR FUTURE

28	Hope	Hebrews 6:19
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29	Glorification	1 Corinthians 15:42–43
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30	Election	Ephesians 1:3–4
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Creation



Two hands reach across empty space and do not quite meet. Nearness was the design. The gap is not the design.

OPEN PART I BY SAYING

For four weeks, start with God. Creation, love, mercy, and grace are not a warm-up. They are who He is. Do not rush past Him to get to our problem. The cross will mean more if the room knows the God who gave His Son.

Before you gather

- Read Day 1, Creation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Psalm 8:3–6 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What is something you made with your hands that you were glad to finish?

Leader. Let them name something ordinary. Then open Psalm 8. The psalm is about the God who made the heavens and then made us. Do not debate the age of the earth. This is worship, not a science class. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: God made us to know Him and to worship Him. Nearness was His design, and we exist for His glory.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Creation is God making the whole world and everything in it. He made people in a special way so we could know, love, and reflect Him.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Hebrew *asah* — to fashion, accomplish, or produce. Greek *poieō* — to make, to create, to do.

MEMORY VERSE · GENESIS 1:26–27

Then God said, “Let us make man in our image, after our likeness.” So God created man in his own image, in the image of God he created him; male and female he created them.

Together, open the flashcard for Creation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Psalm 8:3–6

The memory verse is Genesis 1. Stay in Psalm 8. Ask what the text says before anyone talks about how big the sky makes them feel. Feelings are not the authority. But God gave us these words. Do not reteach the journal.

When I look at your heavens, the work of your fingers, the moon and the stars, which you have set in place, what is man that you are mindful of him, and the son of man that you care for him? Yet you have made him a little lower than the heavenly beings and crowned him with glory and honor. You have given him dominion over the works of your hands; you have put all things under his feet.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In Psalm 8, what belongs to God alone, and what does He give to human beings?

CORE

Leader. The heavens are the work of His fingers. He set the moon and stars in place. To man He gives mindfulness, care, a crown of glory and honor, and dominion. Dignity is a gift from the Maker. We did not seize it.

2. The writer asks, 'What is man that you are mindful of him?' Is this a boast about us, or worship of God?

Leader. It is worship. We are small. God is great, and yet He cares. We were made for God. A talk about creation that never becomes praise has missed the psalm.

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Colossians 1:16 says all things were created through the Son and for Him. What is wrong with a gospel that starts with us and our needs?

Leader. Jesus is the Creator and the goal of all things. He is King. We exist for Him. Worship is the point. A gospel that starts with what we get has the subject wrong.

4. Genesis 3:15 promises an offspring who will crush the serpent, in the same chapter as the fall. Why is that already good news? CORE

Leader. The rescue was not a backup plan. On the day sin entered, God promised a Deliverer. The Creator would not abandon what He made. Jesus came to die. That promise was Plan A.

5. Isaiah 43:7 says God formed a people for His glory. Where do people in our town look for a glory that only God should have?

Leader. Work, a child's sports, a relationship, a reputation, even ministry success. Those are idol factories. Name them without a confession circle. The cure is worship of the true God, not a better self.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

You were made by God and for God, and Jesus came to bring rebels back to Him.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before

you pray.

Invite a neighbor to your table this week and learn their name. See them as someone God made on purpose. Say that God made them for Himself, and Jesus came so sinners could know Him.

Leader. See them, share a table, and talk about the Maker. A meal that never names Jesus is not the whole challenge. If they want a fight about the age of the earth, do not take it. Tell them who made them and why. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, You made the heavens with Your fingers, and You made every person in this room. We worship You.
2. Forgive us for living as if we were the center. You alone are worthy.
3. Send us to one neighbor this week with a table and a true word about Jesus.

Before you stumble

Do not debate the age of the earth. If it comes up, say, 'God made all things, and that is enough for tonight,' and return to Psalm 8. Do not skip to the fall in the first five minutes. The Maker has to be clear before the bad news lands. Do not turn this into journaling about identity. The text speaks.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask which is harder to believe: that they are small under the sky, or that God crowned them and cares. Then read verse 4 again. The answer is in the text, not in how they feel.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 1:1-5. The Word who made all things is the Word who took on flesh. Read it and stop. Jesus was there at creation. This was never a backup plan.

Love



A father pulls a child in and will not let the embrace be polite. Faces close, arms locked. This is love with a body.

Before you gather

- Read Day 2, Love, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Hosea 11:1–4, 8–9 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Who did one kind thing for you this month that you did not earn?

Leader. Keep it concrete. If they stay vague, ask what the person actually did. Then open Hosea 11. God's love is action toward rebels, not a feeling. Do not start with whether they feel loved. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: God's love is not a mood, and it does not cancel His holiness. He gave His only Son to die for sinners.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Love is God choosing to give of Himself for our good. It is God's faithful commitment to rescue and restore. It is seen most clearly in God sending His Son, Jesus, to save sinners.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *agapē* — to love, to delight in, to be well-pleased with.

MEMORY VERSE • JOHN 3:16

For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life.

Together, open the flashcard for Love. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Hosea 11:1–4, 8–9

Stay in Hosea 11. Israel ran. God had loved them, taught them to walk, and still would not give them up. Ask what the text says before anyone describes how love feels. Do

not reteach the journal. But God gave us these words.

When Israel was a child, I loved him, and out of Egypt I called my son. The more they were called, the more they went away... Yet it was I who taught Ephraim to walk; I took them up by their arms... I led them with cords of kindness, with the bands of love. How can I give you up, O Ephraim? My heart recoils within me; my compassion grows warm and tender. I will not execute my burning anger... for I am God and not a man, the Holy One in your midst.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What has the child done in this passage, and what does the Father refuse to do?

CORE

Leader. The more they were called, the more they went away. God will not give Ephraim up. His compassion grows warm. Love here is covenant action toward people who ran, not a compliment for people who behaved.

2. Verse 9 says, 'I am God and not a man,' right after God names His burning anger. How is His love different from ours when we are hurt?

Leader. People withdraw or pay back. God stays the Holy One and stays near. He will not execute His anger the way a man would. Do not say that means love cancels His anger. The verse still names burning anger. He is God.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 5:8 says God shows His love in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. How is that a different order from our relationships?

Leader. We love people who respond. He loved His enemies. Christ died for the ungodly. That order is the gospel. We did not become lovely and then get loved.

4. John 13:1 says Jesus loved His own to the end, in the hour they were about to fail Him. What does that love do? **CORE**

Leader. It stays, and it goes to a cross. He came to die. He was our substitute. This is not romance. It is the Son keeping covenant with people He knew would deny Him.

5. If the cross is the proof of God's love, where are we tempted to measure His love by how this month feels?

Leader. Suffering, silence, a hard week. Feelings are real. They are not the authority. The Spirit leads by the Word (John 16:13; John 17:17). Point them to Romans 5:8 and the blood. Do not rewrite love as God making life feel easy.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

God's love is God giving His Son to die for sinners who were not lovely.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Buy a meal for someone far from Jesus and sit down with them. If they ask why, say God's love is not a mood. He gave His Son to die for sinners who were not lovely.

Leader. Press for a name outside the church. See them, share a table, and talk about Jesus. A kindness that never names Christ is not the whole challenge. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You for loving us while we were still sinners, and for giving Your Son.
2. Forgive us for loving people only when they are easy, and for treating Your love like a mood.
3. Send us this week with a meal and a true word about the cross.

Before you stumble

If someone says love means God is never angry, do not leave it. Say, 'Hosea 11 still names burning anger. Love does not cancel His holiness. The cross is where love and wrath meet in the substitute.' Wrath is week 7. You may say that in one sentence. Do not turn the hour into a therapy circle about who failed to love them.

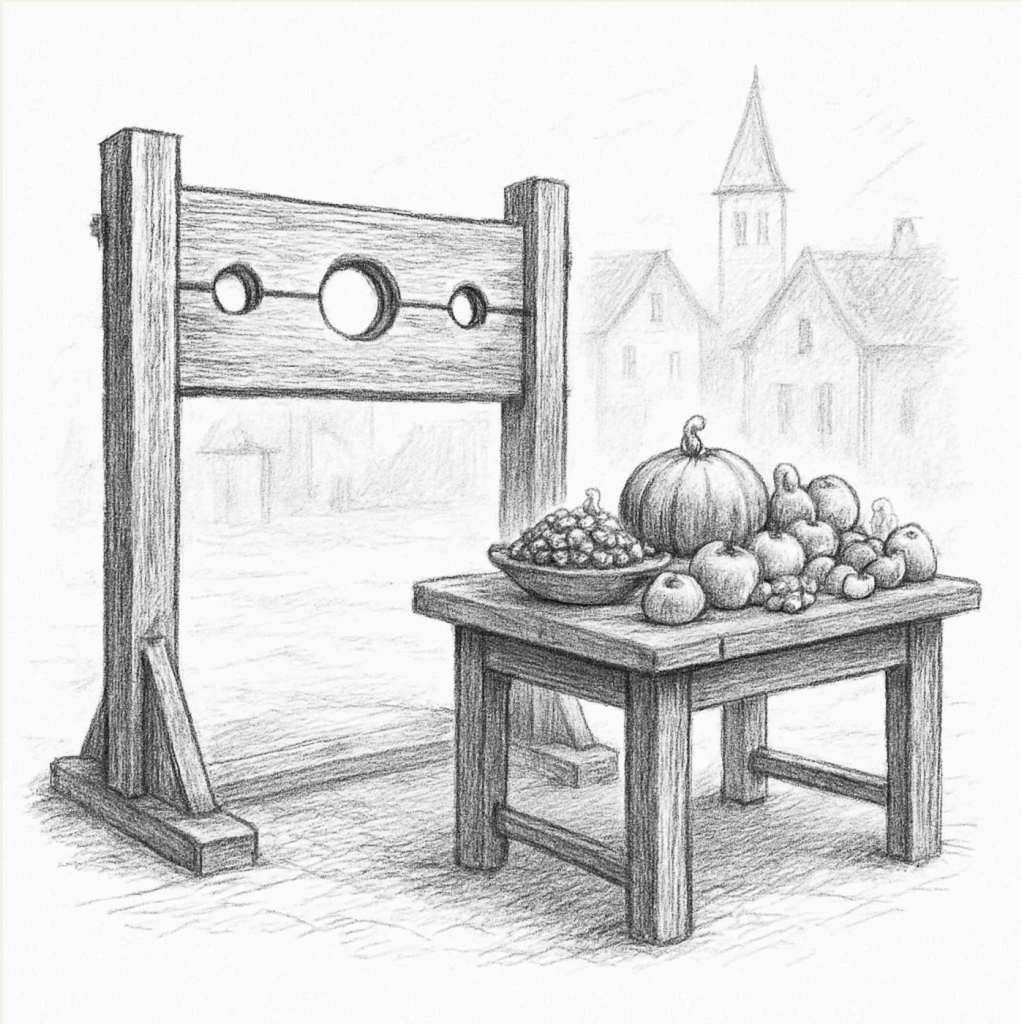
WITH STUDENTS

Students hear love as approval. Ask, 'Does this Father approve of the running, or does He refuse to abandon the runner?' Those are not the same. Read verses 2 and 8. Let the text answer.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

1 John 4:9-10. In this is love: not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son to be the propitiation for our sins. Love has blood in it. Read it if you need a second witness.

Mercy



A town stock is ready for a guilty person. Beside it, the table holds good fruit, not rotten produce to throw. The sentence was real. The gift is real too.

Before you gather

- Read Day 3, Mercy, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Jonah 4:1–2, 10–11 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

When did you brace for a consequence and get kindness instead?

Leader. One sentence. Then open Jonah 4. Mercy in the text is God's, not a warm memory. Do not turn the icebreaker into a journal. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Mercy does not pretend the guilty person deserved a prize. God withholds the judgment sinners earned, and He does it through Christ.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Mercy is God's compassionate withholding of deserved judgment and His tender action toward helpless sinners. It is God's desire to relieve the consequences of sin in those who deserve condemnation through Christ's sacrifice.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek eleos — mercy, kindness, goodwill toward the afflicted.

MEMORY VERSE · 1 PETER 1:3

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead.

Together, open the flashcard for Mercy. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Jonah 4:1–2, 10–11

Jonah can quote mercy and still hate it. Stay in Jonah 4. He wanted judgment for Nineveh and mercy for himself. Ask what the text says. That instinct is still in the room. Do not reteach the journal.

But it displeased Jonah exceedingly, and he was angry. And he prayed to the LORD and said, "O LORD, is not this what I said when I was yet in my country? That is why I made haste to flee to Tarshish; for I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love, and relenting from disaster." And the LORD said, "You pity the plant, for which you did not labor, nor did you make it grow... And should not I pity Nineveh, that great city, in which there are more than 120,000 persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also much cattle?"

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Jonah can quote God's mercy perfectly. What is his actual problem with it? CORE

Leader. He knew the Lord is gracious, merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love, and that is why he fled. He wants mercy for himself and disaster for Nineveh. Right words. Wrong heart.

2. God compares Nineveh to the plant Jonah pitied. What is He saying about the people Jonah had written off?

Leader. Jonah grieved a plant he did not make. God pitied a city of more than 120,000 persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also the cattle. Mercy sees people, not a category to punish.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 Peter 1:3 says that by His great mercy God caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ. What did mercy do besides cancel a penalty?

Leader. Mercy caused new birth. The hope is living because Jesus rose. Mercy is not God looking the other way. It is God acting through the cross and the resurrection.

4. James 2:13 says mercy triumphs over judgment. How can we show mercy without pretending sin is small? **CORE**

Leader. The stocks stay in the picture. The sentence was real. Mercy withholds it because Christ bore it. Mercy that denies guilt is sentiment. Judgment with no Savior is not the gospel. Both stay.

5. Who is a Nineveh you quietly hope will get what is coming? You do not have to say the name. What would pity look like toward them this week?

Leader. A prayer, a meal, a held tongue, a refused insult. Not 'be nicer.' They still need to hear that mercy has a name. Jesus bore the judgment.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Mercy is God withholding the judgment sinners earned, because Jesus bore it.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Withhold the payback you want to give someone far from Jesus. Then say mercy is God not giving the judgment we earned, because Jesus took it on the cross.

Leader. Mercy is not pretending a wrong never happened. It is refusing to finish them, and naming Christ. Do not let the group pick someone already in the church. A kindness that never names Jesus is not the whole challenge. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord, thank You that You are merciful and slow to anger, and that You pitied us.
2. Forgive the Jonah in us: mercy for me, and payback for them.
3. Make us merciful in one concrete way this week, and give us courage to name Jesus.

Before you stumble

If they ask how mercy differs from grace, say it in one sentence and move on. Mercy withholds the judgment we deserve. Grace gives the gift we could never earn. Next week is grace. Do not preview it. If someone says mercy means sin does not matter, correct it. The guilty are not cleared by denial. They are spared by Christ.

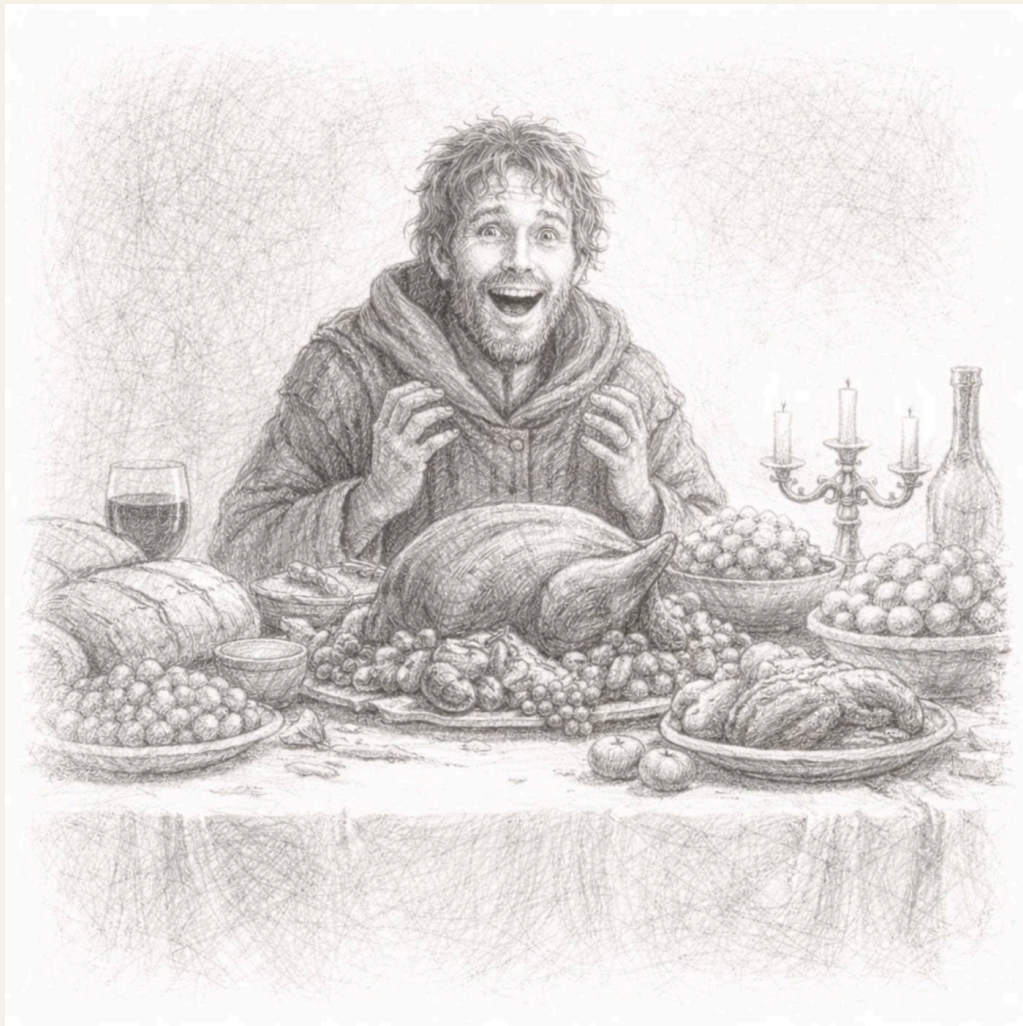
WITH STUDENTS

Ask where students hear 'you get what you deserve' treated as the highest justice. Then ask if they want God to run the world only that way, including toward them. Read Jonah 4:2. The answer is God's character, not their mood.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 6:35-36. Jesus tells His disciples to be merciful as the Father is merciful, including toward the ungrateful. Read it only if the Jonah conversation is still thin.

Grace



A man in a worn coat sits wide-eyed at a table he did not set: bread, meat, fruit, wine. He brought his hunger. God brought the meal.

Before you gather

- Read Day 4, Grace, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read 2 Samuel 9:6–8, 13 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Name one good thing in your life you could not have paid for.

Leader. Stay on inability, not on a favorite gift. Then open 2 Samuel 9. Grace lives where we cannot pay. Do not reteach the journal. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: This man did not set the table. Grace is God feeding sinners who came in empty, at the cost of His Son.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Grace is God's unmerited favor freely given to sinners who deserve judgment, granting them salvation, forgiveness, and every spiritual blessing through Jesus Christ. It is not earned, deserved, or repaid; it flows from God's sovereign goodness and love.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *charis* — grace, favor, a gift freely given.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 2:8–9

For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.

Together, open the flashcard for Grace. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

2 Samuel 9:6–8, 13

Mephibosheth is a lame man from a fallen house. David seats him for Jonathan's sake. Stay in this story. Ask what the text says before anyone talks about how grace makes them feel. But God gave us these words.

And Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, son of Saul, came to David and fell on his face and paid homage. And David said, "Mephibosheth!" And he answered, "Behold, I am your servant." And David said to him, "Do not fear, for I will show you kindness for the sake of your father Jonathan, and I will restore to you all the land of Saul your father, and you shall eat at my table always." And he paid homage and said, "What is your servant, that you should show regard for a dead dog such as I?" ... So Mephibosheth lived in Jerusalem, for he ate always at the king's table.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What had Mephibosheth done to earn a seat, and what exactly did David give him?

CORE

Leader. Nothing earned it. David showed kindness for Jonathan's sake, restored the land, lifted the fear, and gave him a permanent place at the king's table. The reason is another man's covenant, not this man's record.

2. He calls himself a dead dog. Does David argue him into a better opinion of himself, or does he set a place?

Leader. David sets the place. Grace does not wait until we feel worthy. It seats the person who knows he does not belong. The gospel does not start with self-esteem. It starts with the King's kindness.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 2:8-9 says we are saved by grace through faith, and this is not our own doing, so that no one may boast. What do we still try to add as our part?

Leader. Sincerity, a decision, a sad enough repentance, church loyalty, or not being as bad as someone else. Paul says salvation, including the faith that receives it, is the gift of God. Not of

works. No one may boast.

4. Romans 6:1 asks if we should sin so that grace may abound. Where does 'grace means my sin does not matter' get the gift wrong? **CORE**

Leader. Paul says, 'By no means.' We died to sin. Titus 2:11-12 says grace trains us to renounce ungodliness. Grace is not a permit. It is a gift that trains the sinner. Jesus came to die, not to excuse us.

5. 2 Corinthians 8:9 says Christ became poor so that we might become rich. How does that cost keep gratitude from turning into entitlement?

Leader. Entitlement says, 'Of course.' Worship says, 'It cost Him.' He was our substitute. The table is free to us and costly to the Son. Ask what entitlement sounds like in prayer, then go back to the verse.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Grace is God's free gift of salvation to sinners, received by faith in Jesus alone.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Give a real gift to someone far from Jesus who cannot pay you back. Tell them it is not a trade. Grace is God giving sinners what they do not deserve, through faith in Jesus.

Leader. Do not post it. The gift is for them, and the sentence has to name Jesus. A kindness that never names Christ is not the whole challenge. We are sent because He is worthy, not so we can feel generous. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You for a seat at Your table that we did not earn.
2. Forgive the boast we keep trying to add. Salvation is Your gift, through faith.
3. Let grace train us this week, and send us with a gift and a true word about Jesus.

Before you stumble

Part I ends here. Do not start the sin week tonight unless you have time for a clean handoff. A good last line: 'Next time we tell the truth about why this table was necessary.' If someone says they earned a little of it, do not leave that false gospel sitting. Read Ephesians 2:8-9 again. Some will not feel like sinners yet. Do not force a story. The text does the work.

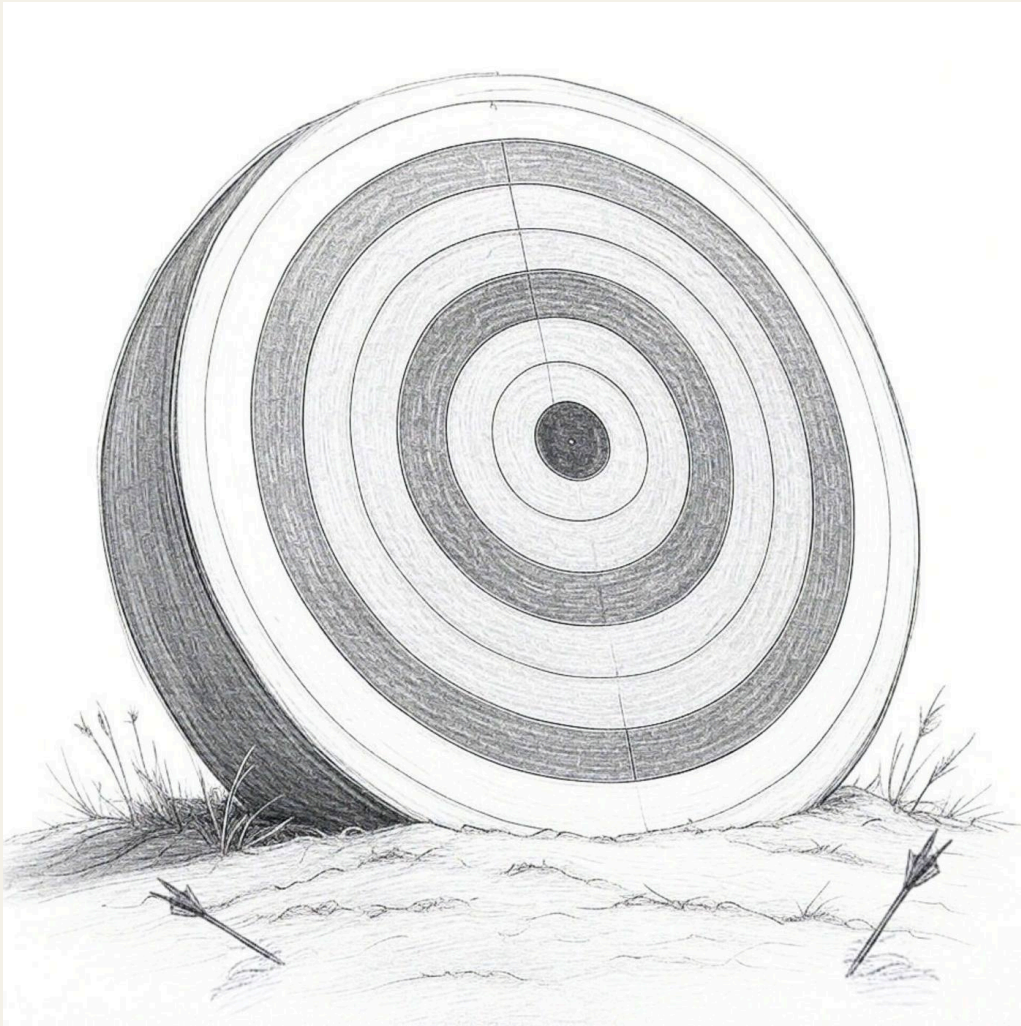
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a team banquet feels like if you did not make the team and someone seats you anyway. Then ask who paid. Keep Jesus as the cost. Christ became poor. The coach is not the Savior.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Titus 2:11-14. The grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation, and it trains us to live godly lives while we wait for our blessed hope. Use it if Romans 6 needs a second witness.

Sin



A full target, and not one arrow in it. The arrows are in the grass. Missing is the point of the drawing, including the shots we never took.

OPEN PART II BY SAYING

Good news is only good if the bad news is true. These five weeks name sin, death, wrath, judgment, and a real guilty verdict. Do not shrink them into low self-esteem. Do not end the night without pointing to Christ.

Before you gather

- Read Day 5, Sin, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Matthew 5:21–22, 27–28 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What rule did you break as a kid, sure that no one would notice?

Leader. Laugh and move. Do not collect shame stories. Then open Matthew 5. Jesus says the heart misses before the hands do. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: These arrows are not close. Sin is falling short of God's glory, not falling short of the person beside you.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Sin is any failure to conform to the moral law of God in act, attitude, or nature, whether by doing what God forbids or failing to do what He commands.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek hamartia — to miss the mark, to err, to trespass.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 3:23

For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.

Together, open the flashcard for Sin. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Matthew 5:21–22, 27–28

Stay in the Sermon on the Mount. Jesus moves the line from the act to the heart. Ask what He says. Do not turn the hour into a confession performance, and do not reteach the journal.

You have heard that it was said to those of old, “You shall not murder; and whoever murders will be liable to judgment.” But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment. You have heard that it was said, “You shall not commit adultery.” But I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. According to Jesus, when is a person already off the mark: only when the act happens, or earlier? **CORE**

Leader. Earlier. Anger with a brother is already liable to judgment. Looking with lustful intent is already adultery in the heart. The heart is guilty before the hands move.

2. Who is Jesus talking to: obvious criminals, or people who thought they were keeping the commands?

Leader. He says, ‘You have heard that it was said.’ These are people who knew the Law and thought they were hitting it. Respectable missing still misses. The standard is God’s, not the group’s.

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. James 4:17 says that whoever knows the right thing to do and fails to do it, for him it is sin. Why do we prosecute loud sins and ignore what we never did?

Leader. We name what we did. God also names what we withheld: truth, help, worship, justice. Omission is sin. Sin is any failure to conform to God's law, in act, attitude, or nature.

4. Romans 3:23 says all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God. Why do we prefer to grade ourselves against other people? **CORE**

Leader. Comparison lets us feel like we almost hit it. The standard is God's glory, His own character. Everyone falls short. There is no curve. All means all.

5. 1 John 1:8-9 says that if we say we have no sin we deceive ourselves, and if we confess, God is faithful to forgive. Why does this room stay polished?

Leader. Image, leadership, family roles. You are not asking anyone to dump a secret. Confession is to God, for forgiveness through the blood of Jesus. It is not group therapy. We name sin in order to bring it to Christ.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Sin is missing God's mark in what we do, what we want, and what we leave undone.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Ask a friend far from Jesus what they think is wrong with the world, and listen. Then own one real way you miss God's mark, and say Jesus came to die for sinners.

Leader. Your own honest miss keeps this from sounding like an attack on them. Still name Christ. A kind conversation that never says Jesus came for sinners is not the whole challenge. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord, show us Your glory as the real target, not a softer one we invented.
2. We confess that we have sinned in what we did, in what we wanted, and in what we left undone.
3. Thank You that Jesus came to die for sinners. Do not leave us under the verdict without the Savior.

Before you stumble

Part II begins. Say that before the icebreaker. Watch two errors. Some will over-talk their failures to prove they are sincere. Thank them, and say we name sin to bring it to Christ, not to perform it. Some will shrink sin to the big list. Read Matthew 5 again. Do not turn the hour into journaling.

WITH STUDENTS

Have them finish this sentence: 'I would never do that, so I am fine.' Then reread Matthew 5:21-22 and 27-28 and ask what Jesus would say back. Let the text answer.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Genesis 3:1-13, if you want the first miss as a story. Ask one question: where do they hide, and from whom? Do not allegory it to death. God still comes looking. The promise of a Deliverer is in the same chapter.

Depravity



A boat, high and dry, hull tired, grass in the seams. It is not a little off course. It is not sailing.

Before you gather

- Read Day 6, Depravity, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Ezekiel 37:1–6, 9–10 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Have you ever pushed a car with a dead battery? What finally had to happen?

Leader. Someone else had to bring power. Do not say the point for them yet. Then open Ezekiel 37. The bones cannot help themselves. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: That boat is not a little off course. It is dead in the sand. Apart from God's grace, so are we.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Depravity refers to the deep corruption of human nature due to sin, resulting in our inability to please God, understand spiritual truth rightly, or come to Him apart from His grace.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek nekros — dead, lifeless, without power. The day's text calls us dead, not merely damaged.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 2:1–2

And you were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked, following the course of this world, following the prince of the power of the air, the spirit that is now at work in the sons of disobedience.

Together, open the flashcard for Depravity. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Ezekiel 37:1–6, 9–10

Ezekiel stands in a valley of very dry bones. God asks if they can live. Stay in the story. Ask what the bones can do. The answer is nothing. God speaks, and breath comes. Do not reteach the journal.

The hand of the LORD was upon me, and he brought me out in the Spirit of the LORD and set me down in the middle of the valley; it was full of bones... and behold, they were very dry. And he said to me, "Son of man, can these bones live?" And I answered, "O Lord GOD, you know." Then he said to me, "Prophecy over these bones... Behold, I will cause breath to enter you, and you shall live." So I prophesied as he commanded me, and the breath came into them, and they lived and stood on their feet, an exceedingly great army.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What can the bones do for themselves in this story, and who acts? CORE

Leader. They are very dry. They do not decide, cooperate, or improve. God says He will cause breath to enter them. Ezekiel prophesies as he is commanded. They live and stand. Life is God's act.

2. God asks, 'Can these bones live?' Ezekiel answers, 'O Lord GOD, you know.' Why is that better than optimism?

Leader. Hope is in God's power, not in the bones' potential. Depravity ends our confidence in human ability. It does not end our confidence in God. He is able to make the dead live.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 2:1 says you were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked. What is the difference between needing a little help and needing to be made alive?

Leader. Help assumes a living patient. Death requires resurrection. Apart from grace we cannot please God, understand the truth rightly, or come to Him. Evangelism is not advice. It is the Word, and prayer that God gives life.

4. Romans 8:7-8 says the mind set on the flesh cannot submit to God's law. Why does that offend us, and why is it good news if it is true? **CORE**

Leader. It offends pride. It is good news because the answer is not 'try harder.' God makes the dead alive in Christ. Jesus came to die and rise for the helpless. This was never a backup plan.

5. John 6:44 says no one can come to Jesus unless the Father draws him. How should that change the way we pray for people who do not care about God?

Leader. Prayer is not a backup plan. If they are dead, asking the Father to draw them is the work, right beside telling them the gospel. We speak. God gives life. Results are His.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Apart from Jesus we are not weak. We are dead, and only God can make us alive.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Help someone far from Jesus before they clean up their life. Tell them we do not need better advice. We need God to make the dead alive, and that is what He does through Jesus.

Leader. Do not run a savior project. Be a neighbor and speak the truth. A kindness that never says they need new life in Christ is not the whole challenge. You cannot raise the dead. God can. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You for any spiritual breath in this room. It did not come from us.
2. We pray by name for people who seem dry. Draw them. Make them alive through Jesus.
3. Humble us. This diagnosis is about us before it is about them.

Before you stumble

Total depravity does not mean everyone is as bad as they could be. People still love their children and tell some truth. It means every part is touched by the fall, and we cannot save ourselves or want the true God on our own. Say that plainly if the phrase scares someone. This is a spiritual diagnosis, not a comment on their worth or their sadness. The image of God from week 1 still stands. Do not turn deadness into a feelings exercise.

WITH STUDENTS

Use the dead battery, not a lecture. Ask, 'What is something you cannot make yourself want?' Then connect that to loving God. Read Ephesians 2:1. Dead is God's word, not an insult.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 11:38-44. Lazarus comes out because Jesus calls. Same point, shorter if Ezekiel ran long. The dead man does not assist the miracle.

Wrath



A storm drops out of a wide sky toward one tree in an open field. Nothing stands between the weather and the tree.

Before you gather

- Read Day 7, Wrath, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Nahum 1:2–3, 7 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

When were you glad that someone in charge got angry at a real wrong?

Leader. Keep the stories short. You are showing that anger can be right before you open Nahum. Then let the text define God's wrath. Do not collect complaints. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: This storm is not God losing His temper. Wrath is His holy anger against sin, and the cross is the only shelter.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

The wrath of God is His holy revulsion against sin and His just judgment against sinners who rebel against His righteous standards.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *orgē* — settled anger, righteous wrath, not a tantrum.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 1:18

For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who by their unrighteousness suppress the truth.

Together, open the flashcard for Wrath. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Nahum 1:2–3, 7

Nahum holds wrath and refuge in one chapter. Stay here. Ask what the text says God is. Do not soften His anger into a mood. It is settled, holy opposition to sin. Do not reteach

the journal.

The LORD is a jealous and avenging God; the LORD is avenging and wrathful; the LORD takes vengeance on his adversaries and keeps wrath for his enemies. The LORD is slow to anger and great in power, and the LORD will by no means clear the guilty. The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. List what Nahum says God is against, and what He is for. Do not skip either list. **CORE**

Leader. He is jealous, avenging, and wrathful toward His adversaries. He is slow to anger and great in power, and He will by no means clear the guilty. He is also good, a stronghold for those who take refuge in Him. Both lists stand.

2. 'Slow to anger' and 'will by no means clear the guilty' sit side by side. What is lost if we keep only one line?

Leader. Only slow to anger: evil never matters. Only wrath: nobody can come home. Do not say love cancels God's anger. Nahum refuses that. The guilty are not cleared by niceness. Refuge is for those who come to Him.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. If God never grew angry at cruelty, what would that say about the people cruelty crushes?

Leader. A god who is never angry does not love the victim. Wrath is His holy revulsion against sin and His just judgment on rebels. God is not neutral. His anger is righteous.

4. Romans 1:18 says the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of people who suppress the truth. Where do you see that already,

without making a speech? CORE

Leader. Romans 1 names the fruit: truth pushed down, bodies used, lies treated as freedom. Wrath is present, not only future. Stay with the text. No partisan talk. The next sentence, if you speak of this outside, must be the cross.

5. How do we talk about God's wrath to a friend without sounding like we enjoy it? What must the next sentence be?

Leader. The next sentence is the cross. Jesus came to die. He was our substitute. He bore the wrath sinners deserve. If they cannot say that second sentence, they are not ready to say the first one in public.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

God's wrath is His holy anger against sin, and Jesus bore it for all who trust Him.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Stand with someone who was harmed by a real wrong. Do not laugh it off or pile on. Then tell a friend that God's wrath is holy anger at sin, and Jesus bore it for sinners who trust Him.

Leader. Keep this off political speeches and off gloating. We stand under the same wrath. The sentence must land on the substitute, not on a villain we enjoy. Words and actions.

Both. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened?
One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord, You are slow to anger, and You will not clear the guilty. We praise Your holiness.
2. Forgive us if we have enjoyed the thought of someone else under the storm.
3. Make us truthful and tender, and help us say that Jesus bore wrath for sinners.

Before you stumble

Two failures: mocking people who struggle with wrath, and gloating as if we were the lightning. Correct both. If someone says God's love cancels His anger, do not leave it. Read Nahum 1:2-3 again. Love does not clear the guilty. The cross does, because the Son was condemned in our place. Do not camp on graphic pictures of hell. Camp in Nahum: He will not clear the guilty, and He is a stronghold.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what kind of god they would want if someone hurt their brother or sister. Most will want a God who gets angry. Then ask if they want that same God reading their phones. Read Nahum 1:7. Refuge is for those who come to Him.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Psalm 7:11-12. God is a righteous judge, and He is indignant every day. If a person does not turn, He prepares His weapons. Wrath does not mean there is no warning. Repentance is still commanded.

Judgment



A judge's bench, formal and empty. The chair is still vacant. The courtroom is not a metaphor we control. The session has not started. It is on the calendar.

Before you gather

- Read Day 8, Judgment, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Acts 17:30–31 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

Open the room

If this week played on a screen, what ten seconds would you skip?

Leader. A little exposure is enough. You may let someone pass. Shut down oversharing. Then open Acts 17. Judgment is God's verdict, not the group's. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: The chair is empty, not retired. God has fixed a day, and the Judge is the man He raised from the dead.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Judgment is God fairly judging every person's life and giving what is due according to His holy and righteous standard. For those apart from Jesus the verdict is always guilty, resulting in eternal punishment.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek krisis — a separating, a trial, a decision, a judgment.

MEMORY VERSE · HEBREWS 9:27

And just as it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment.

Together, open the flashcard for Judgment. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Acts 17:30–31

Paul is preaching to people who are not insiders. God commands all people everywhere to repent, because He has fixed a day. Stay in Acts 17:30–31. The proof is the

resurrection. Do not reteach the journal.

The times of ignorance God overlooked, but now he commands all people everywhere to repent, because he has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed; and of this he has given assurance to all by raising him from the dead.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What has God fixed, whom has He appointed to judge, and what proof does Paul give? **CORE**

Leader. A day. A man, Jesus. The resurrection. Judgment is not a mood. It is appointed, personal, and righteous. God has given assurance to all by raising Him from the dead.

2. Paul says God now commands all people everywhere to repent. What does that do to the idea that judgment is only a church topic?

Leader. The bench covers the whole city, including people who find the idea embarrassing. The times of ignorance God overlooked. Now the command is repent. No one is outside the jurisdiction.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Hebrews 9:27 says it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment. Why do we live as if the second half of that sentence were optional?

Leader. Busyness, entertainment, even ministry can be a way not to look at the chair. Death is appointed. Judgment follows. A feeling that it is 'not yet' does not move the day.

4. Read Hebrews 9:28 right after 9:27. Christ will appear a second time, not to deal with sin but to save those who are waiting for Him. What is the difference between those two futures? **CORE**

Leader. Outside Christ, the day is judgment. In Christ, sin has already been dealt with. The Judge is the Savior. If fear fills the room, read John 5:24: the one who hears and believes does not come into judgment. Do not tell an unbeliever they are already safe.

5. Romans 2:11 says God shows no partiality. Whose sin do we grade on a curve, and whose do we not?

Leader. The curve usually favors people like us. God does not. His standard is His own righteousness. Let that land. Do not turn the night into politics. We stand under the same Judge.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

A real Judge is coming, and His standard is His righteousness, not our excuses.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Make the apology you owe, or stand up for someone being misjudged. Then tell one person far from Jesus that God has fixed a day to judge the world, and that you trust the risen Christ, not your record.

Leader. They stand under the same Judge. If anyone sounds pleased to swing judgment at others, stop them. We do not grade on a curve either. The gospel sentence is repent and trust the risen Jesus. Deeds without that sentence are not the whole challenge. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You that the chair is still empty and there is still time to repent.
2. We pray for people living as if judgment were a myth. Open their eyes to the risen Judge.
3. Thank You that the Judge is Jesus, who died and rose. Make us eager for Him.

Before you stumble

Do not flatten this into 'Christians never face any evaluation.' Second Corinthians 5:10 says we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ. For believers that is not a condemnation hearing. Justification stands. It is still a real appearing. If that is too much for the room, stick to John 5:24 and Hebrews 9:27-28. Do not tell anyone they are safe apart from faith in Christ.

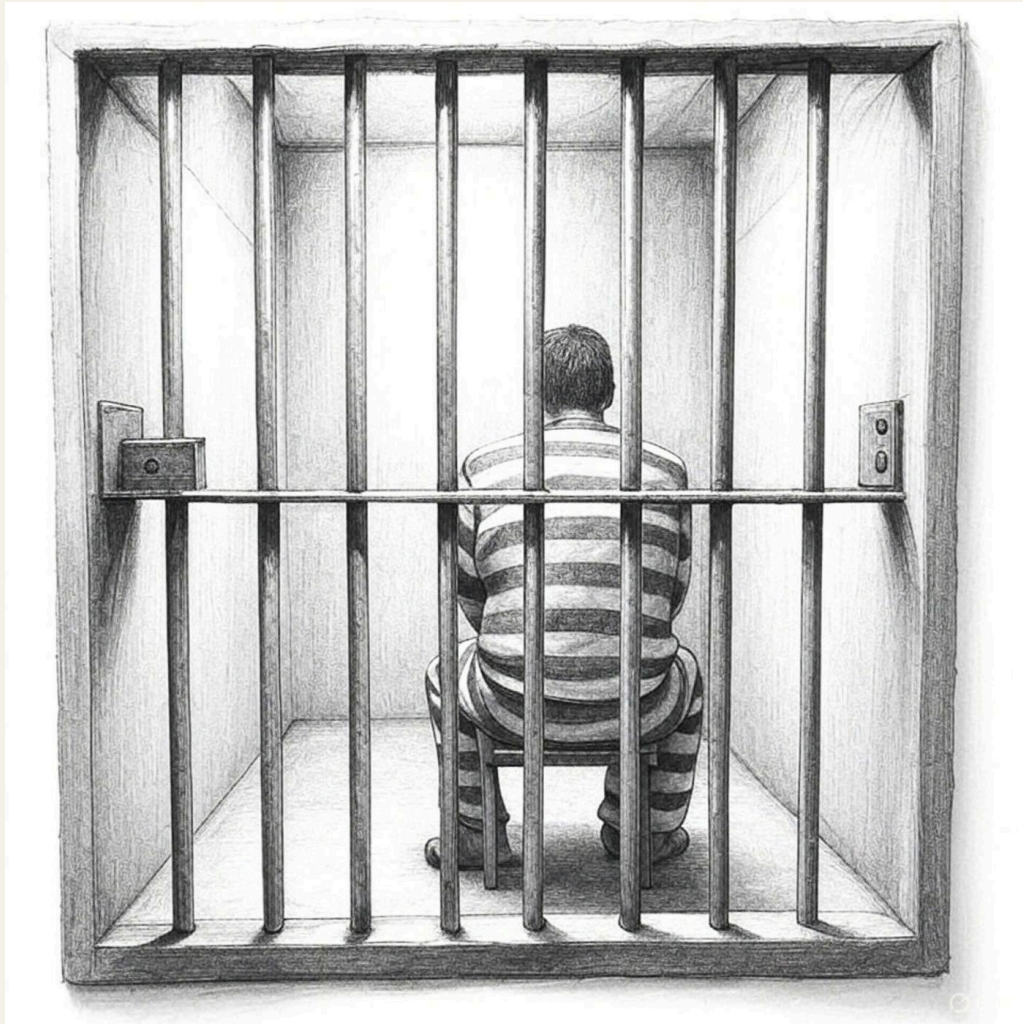
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what would change this month if they believed a day was fixed. Push past 'I would be nicer' to something with a date: a conversation, a habit, an apology. Then ask who the Judge is. The answer is the risen Christ.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Ecclesiastes 12:14. God will bring every deed into judgment, with every secret thing, whether good or evil. Read it if the group thinks only public scandal counts.

Condemnation



A man in prison stripes sits with his back to us. A bar locks the door. We are not watching a bad day. We are looking at a sentence.

Before you gather

- Read Day 9, Condemnation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Galatians 3:10, 13–14 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

Name a courtroom scene from a movie. Did you agree with the verdict?

Leader. Keep it to fiction and one sentence. Then open Galatians 3. The real courtroom is God's. The curse is not a plot point. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Condemnation is a verdict, not a disappointment. Whoever does not believe is condemned already, and the pardon is Christ alone.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Condemnation is God's judicial verdict of guilt for sinners, resulting in the sentence of judgment and eternal separation from God. It is the opposite of justification.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek katakrima — a sentence of guilt, an adverse verdict.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 3:18

Whoever believes in him is not condemned, but whoever does not believe is condemned already, because he has not believed in the name of the only Son of God.

Together, open the flashcard for Condemnation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Galatians 3:10, 13–14

Galatians 3 shows the curse and the exchange. All who rely on works of the law are under a curse. Christ became a curse for us. Ask what the text says before anyone talks

about how condemned they feel. Do not reteach the journal.

For all who rely on works of the law are under a curse; for it is written, “Cursed be everyone who does not abide by all things written in the Book of the Law, and do them.” Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us — for it is written, “Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree” — so that in Christ Jesus the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles, so that we might receive the promised Spirit through faith.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Who is under the curse in verse 10, and what did Christ become in verse 13? CORE

Leader. Everyone who relies on law-keeping is under a curse, because the law requires all of it. Christ redeemed us by becoming a curse for us, hanged on a tree. The sentence moved onto the substitute. He was our substitute.

2. Verse 14 says what arrives on the other side of that exchange. What is it, besides a cleared record?

Leader. The blessing of Abraham comes to the Gentiles, and we receive the promised Spirit through faith. The way in is faith, not works. The door opens onto an inheritance, not onto a second chance to earn it.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. John 3:18 says whoever believes in the Son is not condemned, but whoever does not believe is condemned already. What do you say to a friend who thinks they are a decent person finding their own way?

Leader. Do not tell them they are already safe. The verdict is in. Evangelism is not 'become a better person.' It is 'you are condemned already, and there is a pardon in the name of the only Son of God.' Call them to believe.

4. Romans 8:33-34 asks who will bring a charge and who is to condemn. The answer is Christ, who died, was raised, and intercedes. Why is a living Jesus, not a forgiving feeling, the end of the case? **CORE**

Leader. The one who died and rose is the defense, at the right hand of God. The accuser cannot reopen what God has closed. Feelings of guilt are not the verdict. The risen Christ is. The Spirit leads by the Word (John 16:13; John 17:17).

5. Where do Christians still live as if the cell were locked, replaying a sin Christ has already borne?

Leader. Separate condemnation from conviction. The Spirit exposes sin to lead us to Christ (John 16:8). The accuser exposes sin to send us back to the cell. Romans 8:1 is for those in Christ Jesus. Do not read it over someone who has not believed.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Condemnation is God's guilty verdict. Jesus bore that curse for all who believe.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Do one concrete kindness for someone living under shame. Then say condemnation is a real guilty verdict, and Jesus bore it so that everyone who trusts Him would not carry it.

Leader. Do not tell them they are already safe if they have not trusted Christ. Offer Christ. A kindness that never names the substitute is not the whole challenge. Faith alone, not effort, is how the verdict changes. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord Jesus, thank You for becoming a curse for us on the tree.
2. We pray for people still condemned in John 3:18. Bring them to faith in Your name.
3. Silence accusation that pretends to be holiness, and keep us from calling unbelievers safe.

Before you stumble

Part II ends here. Next time is the manger. Do not skip ahead for fifteen minutes, and do not send the room home under the curse with no Christ. If you are short on time, the last word is Galatians 3:13. Never ask who has been in jail. The drawing is a verdict before God. If someone says decent people are fine, read John 3:18 again. Do not soften it. Do not tell unbelievers they are already safe.

WITH STUDENTS

'Condemned already' sounds harsh. Ask: if a doctor says the disease is already there, is that cruelty or clarity? Then ask what the cure is. Refuse any answer except faith in Christ. Do not tell an unbelieving student they are already safe.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 5:24. Whoever hears and believes has eternal life and does not come into judgment. He has passed from death to life. Leave the verse with them. It is for the one who believes, not for every person in the room by default.

Incarnation



A baby asleep in a feeding trough, straw on the ground, ordinary wood. Glory, taking a nap.

OPEN PART III BY SAYING

Everything before this asked why we need a Savior. These weeks answer with a Person. Incarnation through covenant: He came, He announced, He saved, He died, He stands between, He bought, He made peace, He canceled the debt, and He bound Himself by blood.

OPTIONAL, THREE MINUTES

If the group has been here for the earlier weeks, take three minutes. Ask, in one sentence, why we could not fix what sin, death, wrath, judgment, and condemnation described. The answer to listen for is not 'try harder.' We were guilty and dead. Then open the manger. The Son took flesh to do what we could not. He came to die.

Before you gather

- Read Day 10, Incarnation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Hebrews 2:14–18 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is the most ordinary place you met someone who mattered?

Leader. Ordinary places. The manger is one. Do not ask for a favorite Christmas memory. Then open Hebrews 2. Flesh was required for the cross. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: The eternal Son took a real human body. He came to die, and this was never a backup plan.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

The incarnation is the act of the second person of the Trinity, the eternal Son of God, assuming a full and true human nature, becoming fully God and fully man in one person, Jesus Christ, to accomplish the work of redemption.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek sarx — flesh. The Word became flesh, a real human life.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 1:14

And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth.

Together, open the flashcard for Incarnation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Hebrews 2:14–18

Hebrews 2 says why the Son had to share our flesh and blood: to die, to break the devil's power, and to be a priest who has suffered. Ask the text. Do not settle for a seasonal feeling. Do not reteach the journal.

Since therefore the children share in flesh and blood, he himself likewise partook of the same things, that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, the devil, and deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong slavery. Therefore he had to be made like his brothers in every respect, so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest in the service of God, to make propitiation for the sins of the people. For because he himself has suffered when tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Why did the Son have to share our flesh and blood? Name every reason these verses give. **CORE**

Leader. To die, to destroy the one who had the power of death, to deliver people enslaved by the fear of death, and to become a merciful and faithful high priest who makes propitiation for sins.

He came to die. Incarnation is for salvation.

2. Verse 17 says He had to be made like His brothers in every respect. What is missing if Jesus only seemed human?

Leader. No real death, no real temptation faced, no real priesthood, no propitiation. A costume cannot shed blood. He is the God-man, fully God and fully man, one person. Not God in a disguise.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. John 1:14 says the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen His glory. What does a manger say that a throne by itself could not say?

Leader. The Son came near, into hunger, night, and an ordinary feeding trough, and His glory was full of grace and truth. He did not stop being God there. Nearness serves redemption. It is not a mood.

4. Hebrews 4:15 says we have a high priest who was tempted as we are, yet without sin. Why does that matter on a hard week? **CORE**

Leader. Help comes from a real man who suffered and did not sin. Do not imply that He sinned. The text says the opposite, and that is why His help is clean and His blood is enough. He is able to help those who are tempted.

5. Where do we treat Jesus as an idea or a mood instead of the God-man who lived, died, and rose?

Leader. Prayer that never speaks to Him. A gospel with no body on the cross and no risen body. Worship that wants a feeling more than a King. He is worthy. We are sent because He is Lord, not to have a meaningful experience.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

God the Son took on flesh so He could die and rise as the substitute for sinners.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Go where someone far from Jesus already is, a porch, a shift, or a kitchen. Say that God did not stay at a distance. The Son took on flesh to die and rise for sinners.

Leader. A text message does not finish this. Be present, be a neighbor, and talk about the God-man. A kindness that never names Christ is not the whole challenge. We go because Jesus is King and worthy. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord Jesus, we worship You as God the Son and as the brother who took real flesh.
2. You suffered when tempted and did not sin. Help the one here who is being tempted.
3. Thank You for coming near to make propitiation. Send us out because You are King.

Before you stumble

This is the first week of Part III. Read that line before you start. Correct this kindly and clearly: He did not become God at Bethlehem or at His baptism. He is the

eternal Son who took a human nature. He did not stop being God in the manger. If someone says He was only a good teacher, do not leave that false gospel sitting. Hebrews 2:17 says He made propitiation for sins. If someone is grieving, do not rush past verse 18. The priest who suffered is the help in the text.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask, 'Could Jesus have saved us by staying in heaven and sending a message?' Make them answer from Hebrews 2, not from a slogan. The death required the flesh. He came to die.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Philippians 2:5-11. He took the form of a servant and became obedient to death on a cross. Then God highly exalted Him. Read the descent and the crown. Then worship. Worship is the point.

Gospel



A crier lifts a horn in a crowded street. People lean in, faces open. He is not leading a seminar. He is announcing something that has happened.

Before you gather

- Read Day 11, Gospel, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read 1 Corinthians 15:1–5 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is news you told somebody the same day you heard it?

Leader. News is announced. It is not a tip for a better life. Then open 1 Corinthians 15 and read the facts. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: The gospel is news, not advice. Christ died for our sins, was buried, and rose.
God commands us to repent and believe.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

The gospel is the good news of what God has done in Jesus Christ to save sinners through His life, death, resurrection, and exaltation, calling all people to repent and believe for forgiveness of sins and eternal life.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek euangelion — good news, a message announced, not advice offered.

MEMORY VERSE • LUKE 2:10–11

And the angel said to them, “Fear not, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people. For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord.”

Together, open the flashcard for Gospel. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

1 Corinthians 15:1–5

Luke 2 is the memory verse. Stay in 1 Corinthians 15:1–5. Paul tells a church what the gospel is, of first importance. Ask what the text says before anyone tells their story.

Now I would remind you, brothers, of the gospel I preached to you, which you received, in which you stand, and by which you are being saved, if you hold fast to the word I preached to you — unless you believed in vain. For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures, and that he appeared to Cephas, then to the twelve.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Paul lists events. What are they, and what kinds of things are not on his list? **CORE**

Leader. Christ died for our sins, was buried, was raised the third day, and appeared. Missing: advice, self-help, and a mood. The center is what Jesus did in history, according to the Scriptures.

2. He says they are saved by this gospel if they hold fast. What does that do to a gospel that is only a feeling?

Leader. A feeling is not the gospel. Holding fast means you keep trusting the news of Christ's death and resurrection. Do not send them inward to hunt for a spark.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 1:16 says the gospel is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes. Who saves, and what must a person do?

Leader. God saves. The person believes. We do not add our record to Christ's work.

4. Acts 17:30 says God commands all people everywhere to repent. If the gospel is news, why is there a command? **CORE**

Leader. News demands a response. Repent and believe. Do not leave the room thinking we may ignore it.

5. If you had one minute with a neighbor, which lines from 1 Corinthians 15:3–4 would you actually say?

Leader. Make them say it: Christ died for our sins, was buried, and was raised. Clumsy and true is the goal.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

The gospel is the news that Christ died for our sins, was buried, and rose again, and that we must repent and believe.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Tell one person that Christ died for our sins, was buried, and rose. Then do one ordinary kindness so they know you mean it.

Leader. Lead with His news, not your story. Practice the sentence in the room before anyone leaves. A kindness that never names Christ is not the whole challenge. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You for news that is true whether we feel it or not.
2. Forgive us for turning the gospel into tips and leaving out the cross.
3. Send us to one person this week with 1 Corinthians 15:3–4 on our lips.

Before you stumble

Do not shrink this to “God loves you and has a plan” with no sin, no cross, and no resurrection. Do not say the whole world is already saved. The text says Christ died for our sins, and it calls people to hold fast. Correct a false gospel kindly, and do it.

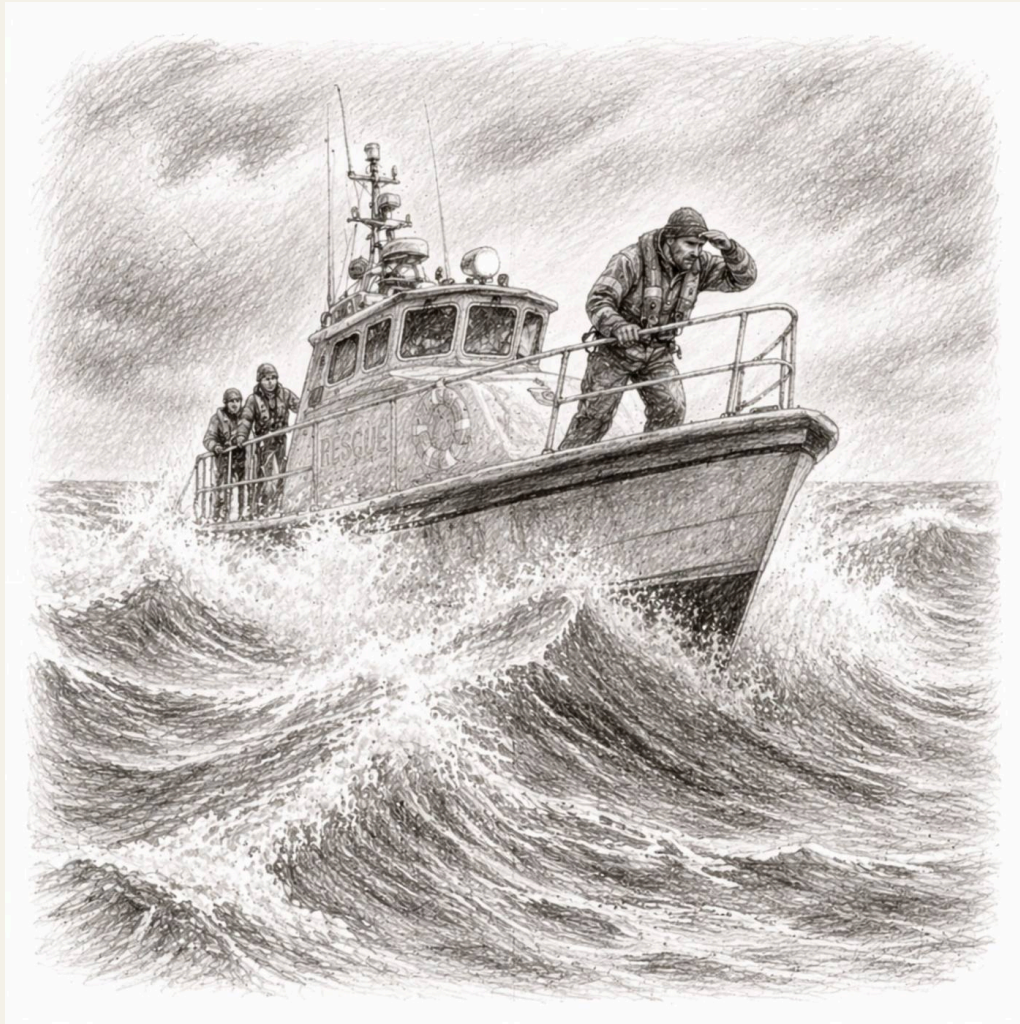
WITH STUDENTS

Have them say “died for our sins, buried, raised” out loud once before they leave. That is the gospel. Then ask who they will tell.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Mark 1:15. The kingdom is at hand. Repent and believe the gospel. Read it and stop.

Salvation



A rescue boat climbs a wave that could bury it. The hull says RESCUE. The crew is already in the weather. Nobody on deck is lecturing the drowning about their stroke.

Before you gather

- Read Day 12, Salvation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Exodus 14:13–14, 30–31 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

When have you been lost and had to be found, not just given directions?

Leader. The point is rescue, not a map. Then open Exodus 14. God fought. Israel stood still. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Salvation is God rescuing sinners. We do not climb out. Jesus came to die, and God raised Him.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Salvation is the gracious and sovereign act of God in which He rescues sinners from sin and judgment through faith in Jesus Christ, restores them to fellowship with Himself, and grants them eternal life by the power of His Spirit.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *sōtēria* — salvation, deliverance, safety, being brought out.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 1:16

For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.

Together, open the flashcard for Salvation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Exodus 14:13–14, 30–31

Romans 1:16 is the memory verse. Stay in Exodus 14. It is the great picture of God saving a people who could not save themselves. Do not retell the journal.

And Moses said to the people, “Fear not, stand firm, and see the salvation of the LORD, which he will work for you today. For the Egyptians whom you see today, you shall never see again. The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent.” Thus the LORD saved Israel that day from the hand of the Egyptians... and Israel saw the great power that the LORD used against the Egyptians, so the people feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in his servant Moses.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In Exodus 14:13–14, what does Moses tell Israel to do, and what does he say the Lord will do? **CORE**

Leader. Fear not. Stand firm. See the salvation of the Lord. The Lord will fight. They only have to be silent — meaning stop trusting their own plan, not hunt for a spiritual feeling.

2. Verse 30 says the Lord saved Israel that day. Who is the subject of the verb?

Leader. The Lord. Not Moses. Not Israel's courage. God saved them. Say that plainly.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 1:16 says the gospel is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes. How is that the same pattern as the sea?

Leader. God does the saving. Faith receives it. Believing is not the power. God is.

4. Ephesians 2:8–9 says salvation is by grace through faith, not our doing. What “doing” do people still offer God? **CORE**

Leader. A cleaned-up life, a prayer said well, church attendance, being better than someone else. Those are not the sea parting. Christ is.

5. Who around you is still trying to save themselves? What one true sentence will you say to them?

Leader. Salvation is God's rescue through Jesus, received by faith. Not a self-rescue. Get a name.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Salvation is God rescuing sinners through Jesus, not us climbing out on our own.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Ask someone far from Jesus what they are counting on if they stand before God. Tell them salvation is God's rescue through Jesus, received by faith. Then help them with one real need.

Leader. Keep the help smaller than the Savior. The sentence has to name Jesus. Do not let them offer advice instead of the gospel. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord, You fight for Your people. We praise You.
2. Forgive us for trusting our own plans more than Christ.
3. Save the one we will name tonight. Give us courage to tell them.

Before you stumble

"Be silent" in Exodus 14:14 is not a call to mystical quiet. It means stop panicking and watch God save. Say that if someone treats silence as the point. And do not tell the room they save themselves by trying harder.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what they would have done at the sea: swim, fight, or cry. Then read verse 13. God says, "See the salvation of the Lord."

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Jonah 2:9. "Salvation belongs to the Lord." Read it if you have a minute. Then pray.

Atonement



A lamb stands in the open and looks at you. Unblemished, alive, and — if you know the story — appointed to die. The softness is not the message. The innocence is.

Before you gather

- Read Day 13, Atonement, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Exodus 12:5–7, 12–13 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Have you ever paid for something someone else broke?

Leader. A cost moved from the guilty to someone else. Then open Exodus 12. The lamb dies. The people live. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Atonement means Jesus, the substitute, died for sinners. His blood covers us. This was the plan, not an accident.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Atonement is the once-for-all work of Christ in His life and sacrificial death in which He, as our substitute, bore the penalty of sin, satisfied God's wrath, fulfilled the demands of divine justice, and reconciled sinners to God, securing redemption for all who believe.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Hebrew *kapar* — to cover, to purge, to make atonement.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 PETER 2:24

He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed.

Together, open the flashcard for Atonement. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Exodus 12:5–7, 12–13

1 Peter 2:24 is the memory verse. Stay in the Passover. The blood on the door is how judgment passed over. Do not skip to a general talk about kindness.

Your lamb shall be without blemish, a male a year old. You may take it from the sheep or from the goats, and you shall keep it until the fourteenth day of this month, when the whole assembly of the congregation of Israel shall kill their lambs at twilight. Then they shall take some of the blood and put it on the two doorposts and the lintel of the houses in which they eat it. The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you, when I strike the land of Egypt.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What kind of lamb does Exodus 12 require, and what is done with its blood? CORE

Leader. A lamb without blemish. The blood is put on the doorposts. God says, "When I see the blood, I will pass over you." The blood, not their goodness, is why death passes over.

2. Who eats the meal, and who is spared? What does that say about a sacrifice no one trusts?

Leader. The household under the blood eats and is spared. A lamb ignored does not cover the house. Do not say the cross saves people who refuse Christ.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 Peter 2:24 says He bore our sins in His body on the tree. Who is the substitute, and whose sins are borne?

Leader. Christ bears the sins of His people in His body. We do not bear them ourselves if we are in Him. He was our substitute.

4. John 1:29: "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world." How does Passover help you say that to a neighbor? CORE

Leader. The lamb dies so the guilty live. Jesus is that Lamb. Practice the sentence. Do not turn it into "be a better person."

5. Hebrews 9:22 says without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness. Why can a sincere apology not replace the cross?

Leader. Sin is against God. He requires blood. Jesus came to die. Our apology does not atone.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Atonement is Jesus, our substitute, covering sin by His blood so we can be brought back to God.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Pay a real cost for someone far from Jesus — a meal, a bill, a mess you did not make. Tell them Jesus died as our substitute, and your payment is only a shadow.

Leader. Do the thing and say the sentence. Do not make them perform gratitude. Do not say everyone is already covered apart from faith. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You for the blood that causes judgment to pass over.
2. Forgive us for trusting our record instead of the Lamb.

3. Send us to speak of the Lamb of God this week.

Before you stumble

Do not say the cross automatically saved every person whether they believe or not. The Passover covered the house under the blood. Also do not shrink the Lamb to a moral example. He died for sins. Correct both errors.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask why the lamb had to be without blemish. Then ask who in the room is without blemish. The answer is Jesus, not them.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Isaiah 53:5–6. He was pierced for our transgressions. Read it if you have three minutes. He was our substitute.

Propitiation



Lightning strikes the church steeple, the cross taking the bolt. The building is not the hero. The cross is where the storm lands.

Before you gather

- Read Day 14, Propitiation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Romans 3:24–26 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

When have you been glad that someone in authority got angry at a real wrong?

Leader. Anger at evil can be right. Then open Romans 3. God's wrath is not a mood. It is answered at the cross. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Propitiation means Jesus took the wrath we deserved. God remains just, and He justifies the one who has faith in Jesus.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Propitiation is the act by which God's just wrath against sin is fully satisfied through a sacrificial substitute, Jesus Christ, so that God's favor and forgiveness can be extended to sinners.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek hilasmos — a sacrifice that turns away wrath, an appeasing.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 JOHN 2:2

He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the sins of the whole world.

Together, open the flashcard for Propitiation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Romans 3:24–26

1 John 2:2 is the memory verse. Stay in Romans 3:24–26. This is where “propitiation” does its work. Do not soften wrath into disappointment.

And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith. This was to show God's righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins. It was to show his righteousness at the present time, so that he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Romans 3:25 says God put Christ forward as a propitiation by His blood, to be received by faith. What did the blood do, and how is it received? **CORE**

Leader. The blood satisfies God's wrath against sin. It is received by faith, not by effort. Say both. Leave either out and you lose the verse.

2. Verse 26 says God is just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus. Why do both words have to stay?

Leader. If He only forgave, justice would be ignored. If He only judged, there would be no gospel. The cross is how He does both. Jesus came to die.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 John 2:2 says Christ is the propitiation for our sins. What must we not say about the Father's anger?

Leader. Do not say love means God was never angry at sin. Propitiation means wrath was spent on Christ, not cancelled as if it were unreal.

4. If a friend says, "A loving God would never be angry," what verse will you open, and what sentence will you say? **CORE**

Leader. Romans 3:25–26. God is just, and He justifies sinners through the blood of Jesus, received by faith.

5. Hebrews 2:17 says Jesus was made like us to make propitiation for the sins of the people. Why did the Savior need a real human life?

Leader. Wrath had to land on a real substitute, a real man who is God. He did not shout forgiveness from a distance. He came to die.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Propitiation means Jesus took the wrath we deserved, so God is just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Where anger sits between you and someone far from God, move toward them without pretending the wrong was nothing. Say that God does not ignore sin, and that Jesus bore the wrath sinners deserve.

Leader. If the relationship is unsafe, do not send them back into harm. Peacemaking is not foolishness. The sentence must keep both justice and the cross. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Holy God, You are right to hate sin. We worship You.
2. Thank You for putting Christ forward as a propitiation by His blood.
3. Give us faith in Jesus, and give us words for one person who thinks You could never be angry.

Before you stumble

Two errors will show up. One says God is love and therefore never wrathful. The other says God is angry and the cross changes nothing. Romans 3:26 answers both. Do not say everyone is already propitiated apart from faith. The verse says “received by faith.”

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what happens to a judge who lets the guilty go with no payment. Then ask what happened at the cross. Keep it short. God is just, and He justifies.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Isaiah 53:10–11. It was the will of the Lord to crush Him. This was Plan A. Read it and pray.

Justification



A gavel has come down on the block. The sound is the point. A court has spoken. The defendant does not leave “mostly improved.” The defendant leaves with a verdict.

Before you gather

- Read Day 15, Justification, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Romans 4:4–8 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day’s reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

Have you ever been cleared of something people assumed you had done?
What changed when the verdict was read?

Leader. A verdict changes your standing in a moment. Then open Romans 4. God counts righteousness apart from works. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Justification means God declares sinners righteous as a gift, because of Jesus, through faith. It is a verdict, not a process.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Justification is the judicial act of God in which He declares sinners righteous in His sight, not on the basis of their works, but solely on the basis of Christ's righteousness imputed to them and received by faith alone.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *dikaioō* — to declare righteous. A verdict, not a process of self-improvement.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 3:24

And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.

Together, open the flashcard for Justification. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Romans 4:4–8

Romans 3:24 is the memory verse. Stay in Romans 4:4–8. Paul uses Abraham and David so no one can turn justification into self-improvement.

Now to the one who works, his wages are not counted as a gift but as his due. And to the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness, just as David also speaks of the blessing of the one to whom God counts righteousness apart from works: “Blessed are those whose lawless deeds are forgiven, and whose sins are covered; blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin.”

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Romans 4:4–5 sets wages against a gift. What does God justify, and what does the person do? **CORE**

Leader. God justifies the ungodly. The person believes. Faith is counted as righteousness. Wages are what you earn. The gospel is not wages.

2. David says, “Blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin.” Whose counting matters?

Leader. The Lord's. Not the room's opinion. Not the person's memory of failure. God does not count sin against the one He justifies.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. How is justification different from sanctification? Use one sentence a new believer could repeat.

Leader. Justification is God declaring you righteous now, by faith in Christ. Sanctification is God making you holy over time. Do not mix them.

4. If someone says, “God helps those who help themselves,” what does Romans 4:5 answer? CORE

Leader. God justifies the ungodly. He does not wait for us to become godly and then declare it. Jesus came to die for the ungodly.

5. 2 Corinthians 5:21: God made Christ who knew no sin to be sin, so that in Him we become the righteousness of God. Who is the substitute?

Leader. Christ. Our sin is counted to Him. His righteousness is counted to us. That is the great exchange. Say it.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Justification means God declares sinners righteous as a gift, because of Jesus, received by faith.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Speak up for someone being summed up by their worst day. Then tell them God does not grade sinners up. He declares the ungodly righteous through faith in Jesus.

Leader. The action is a true word in their defense. The sentence has to stay a gift. Do not say “God knows your heart is basically good.” Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Righteous God, thank You for a verdict we did not earn.
2. Forgive us for bringing You our wages and calling it faith.
3. Help us tell one ungodly friend that You justify those who trust Jesus.

Before you stumble

Do not let justification become “God makes you better and then accepts you.” Romans 4:5 will not allow it. Also do not say a person is justified who refuses to believe. Faith receives the gift. If someone is crushed by old sin, read verse 8 slowly. The Lord does not count it against them.

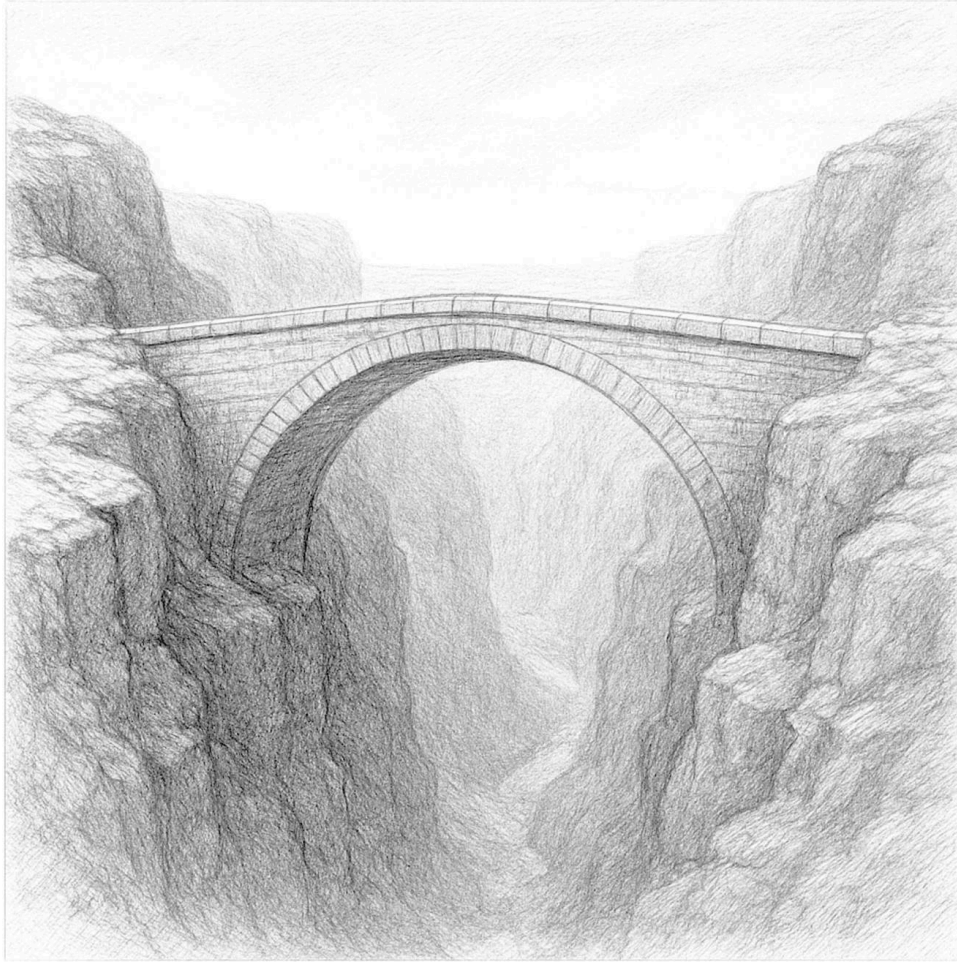
WITH STUDENTS

Use a gradebook if you must. Justification is not extra credit. It is Christ's perfect record written on their name, and the old page torn up. Then ask if that feels unfair. Say: the Someone else asked for it.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Galatians 2:16. A person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ. Read it and stop.

Mediation



A stone arch crosses a gorge no one is going to jump. The cliffs do not move closer. The bridge is the only way, and it had to be built from both sides.

Before you gather

- Read Day 16, Mediation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Hebrews 7:23–25 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What gap would you not try to cross without someone to go between?

Leader. A gap needs a go-between. Then open Hebrews 7. Jesus always lives to intercede. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: There is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus, who gave Himself as a ransom. We are not the mediator.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Mediation is the work of Jesus Christ, the God-man, by which He stands between God and sinful humanity as the only representative who reconciles the two by His atoning death and ongoing intercession as our Great High Priest.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek mesitēs — one who stands in the middle, a go-between.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 TIMOTHY 2:5–6

For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all.

Together, open the flashcard for Mediation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Hebrews 7:23–25

1 Timothy 2:5–6 is the memory verse. Stay in Hebrews 7:23–25. The point is Christ's priesthood, not our spiritual effort.

The former priests were many in number, because they were prevented by death from continuing in office, but he holds his priesthood permanently, because he continues forever. Consequently, he is able to save to the uttermost those who draw near to God through him, since he always lives to make intercession for them.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Why could the old priests not continue forever, and what does verse 24 say about Jesus? **CORE**

Leader. They died. Jesus holds His priesthood permanently because He continues forever. He is able to save to the uttermost those who draw near through Him.

2. Verse 25 says He always lives to make intercession. What is He doing now for those who draw near?

Leader. He prays for them. He is not done at the cross and then absent. He saves to the uttermost. Draw near through Him, not through another priest.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 Timothy 2:5 says there is one mediator, the man Christ Jesus. What does “one” forbid?

Leader. Any other go-between: a saint, a pastor, Mary, your own record. One mediator. Say it clearly and kindly.

4. Verse 6 says He gave Himself as a ransom for all. How do you say that to a friend without turning yourself into their priest? **CORE**

Leader. Point them to Jesus. Tell them He died as a ransom. Offer to pray with them. Do not stand in His place.

5. Hebrews 4:15–16 says we have a high priest who sympathizes, so we draw near with confidence. What keeps people from drawing near?

Leader. Shame, the idea that they must clean up first, or trust in someone else. The text says draw near through Him.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Jesus is the one mediator. He gave Himself as a ransom, and He still lives to pray for His people.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Help someone who has no one to speak for them — a meeting, a bill, a hard conversation. Then tell them there is one mediator, the man Christ Jesus, who gave Himself as a ransom.

Leader. Say out loud that you are not the mediator if anyone starts to feel heroic. Name Christ. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord Jesus, You are the one mediator. We come through You.

2. Thank You that You live to intercede for Your people.
3. Give us courage to point one person to You and not to ourselves.

Before you stumble

Do not let the room invent other mediators. And do not let a helpful Christian become the hero of someone else's standing before God. One mediator. Also "ransom for all" is a real offer to be preached to all. It does not mean every person is already saved apart from faith.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask who they would want to walk into the principal's office with them. Then ask why Jesus is better than that friend. He died and He lives.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 14:6. No one comes to the Father except through Him. Read it if someone is still looking for another door.

Redemption



A standing man places the price into open hands. Someone kneels, no longer clutching what he owed. Freedom here has a receipt.

Before you gather

- Read Day 17, Redemption, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read 1 Peter 1:18–19 and Mark 10:45 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

Open the room

What have you been glad to be done with because somebody else finished paying?

Leader. A debt ended because someone paid. Then open 1 Peter 1. We were ransomed with the blood of Christ. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Redemption means Jesus paid with His blood to free us from slavery to sin. We were bought. We are not our own.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Redemption is God's gracious act of purchasing and freeing His people from slavery to sin, death, and judgment through the payment of Christ's blood, securing their release and restoration to Him.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *apolytrōsis* — a release secured by the payment of a ransom.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 1:7

In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace.

Together, open the flashcard for Redemption. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

1 Peter 1:18–19 and Mark 10:45

Ephesians 1:7 is the memory verse. Stay in 1 Peter 1:18–19 and Mark 10:45. The price is blood, not silver.

You were ransomed from the futile ways inherited from your forefathers, not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot. For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. 1 Peter 1:18–19 says you were ransomed from the futile ways of your fathers. With what? Not with what? **CORE**

Leader. Not with silver or gold. With the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish. The old life was futile. The price was blood.

2. Mark 10:45: the Son of Man came to serve and to give His life as a ransom for many. Why did He come?

Leader. He came to die. Service and ransom belong together. He did not come only to inspire us.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 Corinthians 6:19–20 says you are not your own, for you were bought with a price. What does a bought person stop doing?

Leader. They stop living as if their body and their week belong to them. Glorify God. Be concrete, not vague.

4. If a friend thinks they are free because they answer to nobody, how does redemption tell the truth? **CORE**

Leader. Freedom from God is slavery to sin. Real freedom is being bought by Christ. Say that with kindness, and say it.

5. Who near you is stuck under a real burden? What can you loosen this week, and what sentence about the blood will you add?

Leader. A ride, a bill, an afternoon. Then: Jesus paid with His blood to free sinners. Your help is not the ransom.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Redemption means Jesus paid with His blood to free us from slavery to sin and bring us to God.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Loosen one real bind for someone far from Jesus — a bill, a ride, an afternoon. Tell them Jesus paid with His blood to free sinners. Your help is not the ransom.

Leader. Do not promise a miracle you cannot keep. Name a freedom that is real and small, and name the blood. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord Jesus, You gave Your life as a ransom. We praise You.
2. Forgive us for living as if we were not bought.
3. Free the one we will name, and give us words about Your blood.

Before you stumble

Do not turn redemption into God paying Satan a fee, as if the devil set the price. The price is the blood God required, and Christ paid it. Also do not say people are redeemed who will not have Christ. Call them to trust Him.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what they would do if someone else paid a debt they could not pay. Then read Mark 10:45. He came to give His life.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Titus 2:14. He gave Himself to redeem us and to purify a people. Read it. Redemption leads to holiness, not to doing whatever we want.

Reconciliation



A wall has been broken open. Rubble on both sides, light pouring through the gap. Peace here is not a feeling that the wall was never real. The wall came down.

Before you gather

- Read Day 18, Reconciliation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Ephesians 2:13–18 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

Open the room

What small wall do people build without noticing — a closed door, a seat saved, a silence?

Leader. Name a real distance. Then open Ephesians 2. The wall that mattered was between us and God, and between peoples. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Reconciliation means God ended the war our sin started. The blood of the cross brought enemies near. We do not make peace on our own.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Reconciliation is God ending the war and separation our sin created by the blood of His Son, Jesus Christ, and granting us lasting peace with Himself.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *katallagē* — a change from enmity to friendship. Also *eirēnē* — peace.

MEMORY VERSE • COLOSSIANS 1:19–20

For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.

Together, open the flashcard for Reconciliation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Ephesians 2:13–18

Colossians 1:19–20 is the memory verse. Stay in Ephesians 2:13–18. Far off, brought near by the blood of Christ. Do not start with relationship advice.

But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ. For he himself is our peace, who has made us both one and has broken down in his flesh the dividing wall of hostility by abolishing the law of commandments expressed in ordinances, that he might create in himself one new man in place of the two, so making peace, and might reconcile us both to God in one body through the cross, thereby killing the hostility. And he came and preached peace to you who were far off and peace to those who were near.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Ephesians 2:13. What were we, and what brought us near? CORE

Leader. We were far off. The blood of Christ brought us near. Not our effort to be nicer. The blood.

2. Verse 14 says He is our peace, who broke down the dividing wall. Who made the peace?

Leader. Christ. He made one new man. He reconciled both to God in one body through the cross. Peace is a Person and a death, not a mood.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 5:10 says while we were enemies we were reconciled by the death of His Son. What were we before the cross did its work?

Leader. Enemies, not basically good people having a rough patch. Say the word enemies. Then say the death of the Son.

4. If two people in town will not speak, how is the gospel more than “you should apologize”? CORE

Leader. God made peace with enemies through the blood of His Son. We forgive and move toward people because He moved toward us. Apology without Christ is not the gospel.

5. 2 Corinthians 5:18–20 says God reconciled us and gave us the ministry of reconciliation. What are we supposed to say?

Leader. Be reconciled to God. We are ambassadors. The message is about God, not only about two neighbors getting along.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Reconciliation means God ended the war our sin started, through the blood of the cross, and brought us near.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Take one step toward a person you are distant from who does not follow Jesus. If you owe an apology, give it. Tell them God makes peace with enemies through the blood of His Son.

Leader. If the other person is unsafe, tell the truth from a distance. Do not force a reunion. The sentence is about being reconciled to God. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, we were far off, and You brought us near by the blood of Christ.
2. Forgive us for keeping wars You have told us to end.
3. Make us ambassadors this week. Open one mouth to say, "Be reconciled to God."

Before you stumble

Do not turn this into relationship advice with Jesus as an illustration. The wall in the text is hostility toward God, and hostility between peoples, broken at the cross. Horizontal peace comes from vertical peace. If someone wants only the horizontal, bring them back to verse 16.

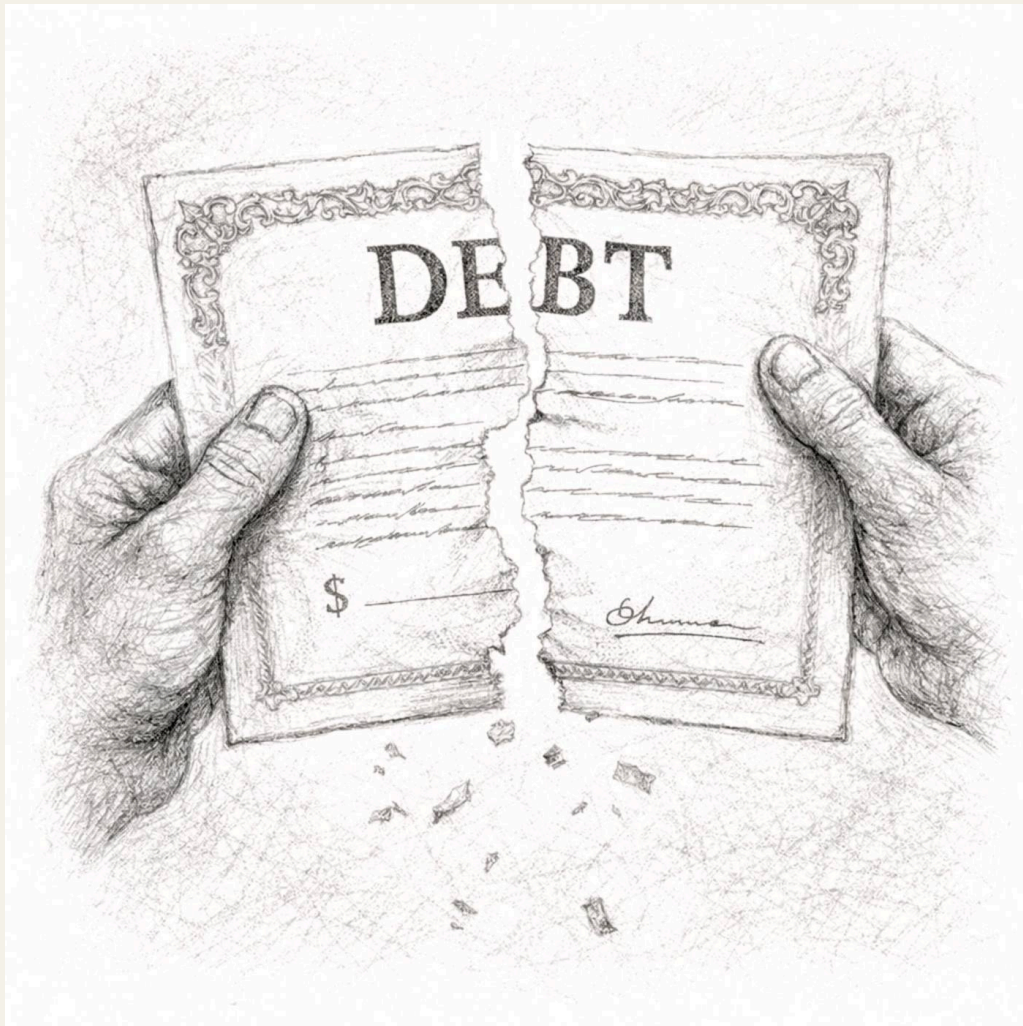
WITH STUDENTS

Ask who at school is "far off" from them. Then read verse 13. Christ brings the far off near by His blood. Ask who they will move toward.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Colossians 1:21–22. You were alienated and hostile. He has now reconciled you in His body of flesh by His death. Read it and give thanks.

Forgiveness



Two hands tear a sheet that says DEBT. The rip is down the middle. Scraps fall. Forgiveness is not a payment plan. The paper does not get taped together.

Before you gather

- Read Day 19, Forgiveness, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Luke 7:41–48 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What bill or reminder would you love to see stamped paid and gone?

Leader. A real debt, cancelled. Then open Luke 7. Jesus talks about two debtors, and a woman who knows she was forgiven much. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Forgiveness means God cancels the debt of sin in Christ and does not hold it against His people. The debt was real. The cross paid it.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Forgiveness is the gracious act of God by which He fully pardons sinners of their guilt, cancels their debt of sin, and no longer holds their transgressions against them because of Christ's work on the cross.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek aphasis — release, pardon, the cancellation of a debt.

MEMORY VERSE • COLOSSIANS 1:14

In whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins.

Together, open the flashcard for Forgiveness. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Luke 7:41–48

Colossians 1:14 is the memory verse. Stay in Luke 7:41–48. Forgiveness is a cancelled debt, and it shows up in love for Jesus.

"A certain moneylender had two debtors. One owed five hundred denarii, and the other fifty. When they could not pay, he cancelled the debt of both. Now which of them will love him more?" Simon answered, "The one, I suppose, for whom he cancelled the larger debt." And he said to him, "You have judged rightly." ... And he said to her, "Your sins are forgiven." Then those who were at table with him began to say among themselves, "Who is this, who even forgives sins?" And he said to the woman, "Your faith has saved you; go in peace."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In the parable, what is different about the two debtors, and what is the same? CORE

Leader. One owed more. Both could not pay. The lender cancelled both debts. The difference is not that one was able. Neither could pay.

2. Jesus asks who will love the lender more. What does He say about the woman, and what does He say to her?

Leader. She loved much because she was forgiven much. He says, "Your sins are forgiven... Your faith has saved you; go in peace." Faith, not her tears, saved her. The tears showed she knew the debt.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Colossians 2:13–14 says God cancelled the record of debt by nailing it to the cross. Where did the record go?

Leader. To the cross. It was not ignored. It was nailed there in Christ. Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness.

4. Matthew 6:14–15 and Ephesians 4:32 belong together. Why do forgiven people forgive? CORE

Leader. Because God in Christ forgave them. We do not forgive to earn His forgiveness. We forgive because we have received it. Do not reverse that.

5. Who are you still charging for a debt Christ has told you to release? What will you do this week?

Leader. Name a grudge without a long story. Cancel it. If the person does not know Christ, tell them God cancels sin's debt in Jesus.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Forgiveness means God cancels our debt of sin in Christ and does not hold it against us.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Release a real grudge against someone outside the church — stop retelling the story, stop charging them. Tell them you are letting it go because God cancels sin's debt in Christ. Invite them to Jesus.

Leader. Forgiveness is not saying the wound was fine. It is laying down the right to punish. Say that before they leave. Do not tell an unbeliever they are already forgiven if they will not have Christ. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You for cancelling a debt we could not pay.
2. Forgive us for keeping books You have closed.
3. Help us forgive one person this week, and to tell them about Jesus.

Before you stumble

Do not say “forgive yourself.” The text has a Lender, and He cancels the debt. Also do not say forgiveness means there was no wrong. Luke 7 is about a real debt. And do not tell the room that tears save. Jesus says, “Your faith has saved you.”

WITH STUDENTS

Ask which debtor they are, the one who owed more or the one who owed less. Then say both could not pay. That is the point. Christ paid.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Psalm 103:12. As far as the east is from the west, so far does He remove our transgressions from us. Read it as praise, not as a new lesson.

Covenant



A bride and groom face each other under a flowering arch, hands held. Vows, not a handshake deal. Joy, and a bond that is meant to hold.

OPTIONAL, THREE MINUTES

Before the icebreaker, three minutes. Which word from incarnation through covenant do you least want to forget, and why? One sentence. No speeches. Then open Genesis 15.

Before you gather

- Read Day 20, Covenant, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Genesis 15:7–18 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What promise has someone kept long after it stopped being easy?

Leader. A kept promise. Then open Genesis 15. God walks the aisle alone. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: A covenant is God binding Himself to His people by promise. The new covenant stands because Jesus shed His blood. This was the plan all along.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

A covenant is a divinely established, binding relationship in which God commits Himself to His people with promises and often confirms it with signs and blood.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *diathēkē* — a covenant, a binding commitment, a testament.

MEMORY VERSE • HEBREWS 9:15

Therefore he is the mediator of a new covenant, so that those who are called may receive the promised eternal inheritance, since a death has occurred that redeems them from the transgressions committed under the first covenant.

Together, open the flashcard for Covenant. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Genesis 15:7–18

Hebrews 9:15 is the memory verse. Stay in Genesis 15. Abraham does not march through the pieces. God commits Himself. Do not turn this into a lecture on every covenant in the Bible.

And he said to him, "I am the LORD who brought you out from Ur of the Chaldeans to give you this land to possess." ... "Know for certain that your offspring will be sojourners... and they shall come back here." When the sun had gone down and it was dark, behold, a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch passed between the pieces. On that day the LORD made a covenant with Abram, saying, "To your offspring I give this land."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In Genesis 15, who passes between the pieces, and who is put to sleep? **CORE**

Leader. Abraham is asleep. A smoking fire pot and a flaming torch — God — pass between the pieces. God binds Himself. Abraham does not earn the promise.

2. What does God promise in the verses you read, and what does Abraham contribute?

Leader. Offspring, land, and God as his shield and reward. Abraham believes. He does not negotiate terms. Faith receives the promise.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Hebrews 9:15 says a death has occurred that redeems, so the called receive the promised eternal inheritance. Why was blood required?

Leader. A covenant with guilty people needs a death. Jesus is the mediator of a new covenant. Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness.

4. Luke 22:20: "This cup is the new covenant in my blood." What should we remember at the Lord's table? **CORE**

Leader. We proclaim His death. The cup is His blood, poured out. The new covenant stands because He died, not because we are reliable. Jesus came to die.

5. Jeremiah 31:33–34. God says "I will." Which of His promises do we live as if He might take back?

Leader. He will write His law on hearts, be their God, and remember their sin no more. The new covenant is God's "I will," not our "we might."

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

A covenant is God binding Himself by promise, and the new covenant stands because Jesus died.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Keep a real promise this week to someone who has been let down, especially if they do not trust Christians. Tell them God binds Himself by promise, and the new covenant stands because Jesus shed His blood.

Leader. “I’ll pray for you” does not count unless you also do the thing you promised. The sentence is about God’s promise, not about how dependable you are. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Faithful God, thank You for promises that do not rest on us.
2. Forgive us for breaking our word and then doubting Yours.
3. Help us keep one promise this week, and to point to the blood of the new covenant.

Before you stumble

Do not flatten every covenant into the same terms. In Genesis 15, God walks alone. Sinai will include commands. The new covenant fulfills both: law on the heart, and a death that secures the inheritance. If the room is new, you need this: God commits Himself, and Jesus’ blood is why we inherit. Do not end on Abraham. End on the cup.

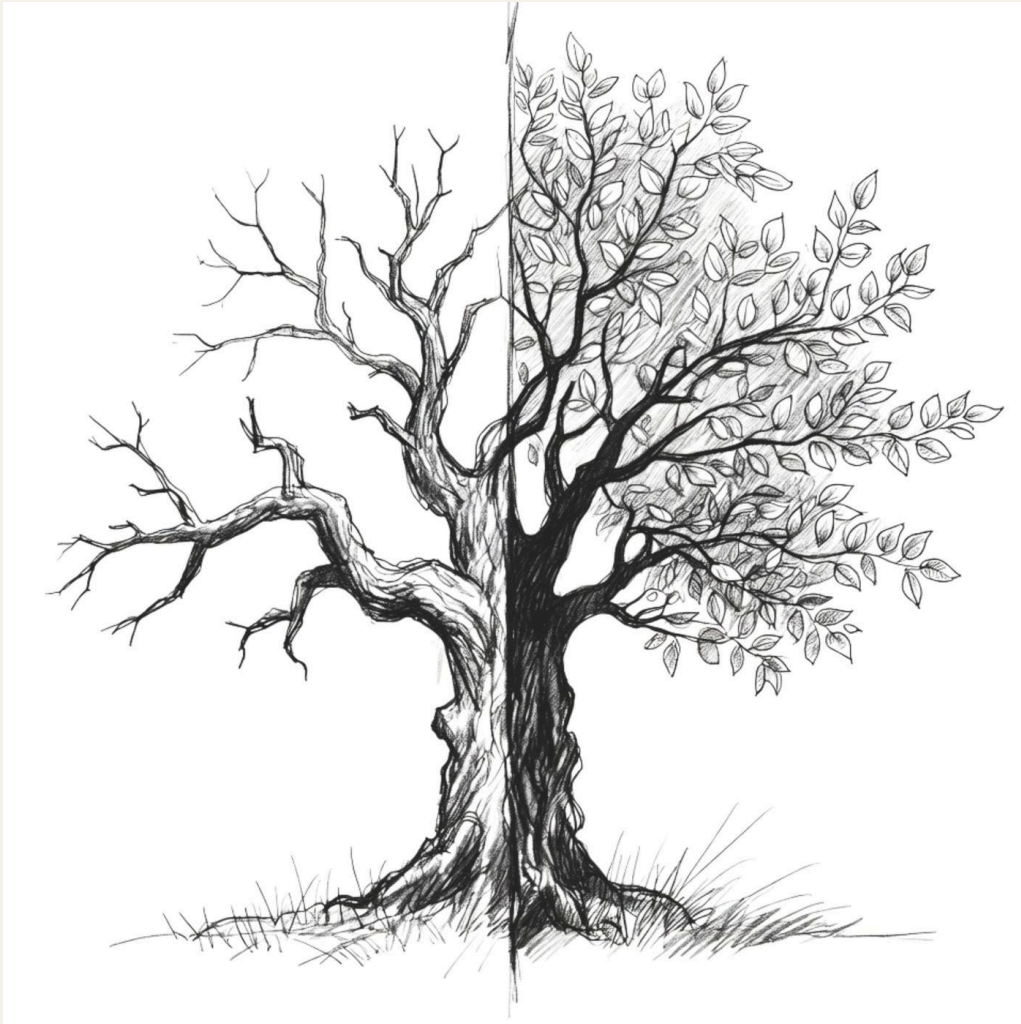
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what happens to a group project when only one person is reliable. Then ask why it is good news that God passed through the pieces alone.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 22:20 again, out loud, if you have one minute. “This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood.” Then pray.

Regeneration



One tree, split down the trunk. Dead wood on one side, leaves on the other. Same roots, two conditions. The life is not a coat of paint on the dead half.

OPEN PART IV BY SAYING

Christ's work is finished. It does not land on a person by magic. The Spirit gives life, seals, adopts, and rescues. He brings sinners to faith and repentance, then keeps making them like Jesus. These weeks are about how the gospel gets inside a real person.

Before you gather

- Read Day 21, Regeneration, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read John 3:3–8 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What have you seen that looked fine on the outside and was dead on the inside?

Leader. Dead versus alive. The book already asked what changed when they came to Christ, and what to put off from 2 Corinthians 5:17. Do not retake that journal. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: This tree did not try harder. God makes the dead alive. Regeneration is the Spirit's work of new birth, not self-improvement. You do not achieve it. He raises you.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Regeneration is being born again through the Holy Spirit. It is a supernatural work of God in which a spiritually dead person is made alive.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek palingenesia — rebirth, regeneration. Also zōopoieō — to make alive.

MEMORY VERSE • TITUS 3:5

He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit.

Together, open the flashcard for Regeneration. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

John 3:3–8

Titus 3:5 is the memory verse. John 3 puts Jesus in front of a religious man: unless you are born from above, you cannot see the kingdom. The Spirit gives that life by the Word. He is not steered by our feelings.

Jesus answered him, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God." Nicodemus said to him, "How can a man be born when he is old?" ... Jesus answered, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God. That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit. Do not marvel that I said to you, 'You must be born again.' The wind blows where it wishes, and you hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who is born of the Spirit."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Nicodemus is a serious religious teacher. What does Jesus say he still cannot do unless he is born again? CORE

Leader. See and enter the kingdom of God. Religion without new birth leaves him outside. God must make the dead alive (John 3; Ephesians 2:1–5). Competence is not life.

2. Jesus compares the Spirit to the wind. What can you observe, and what can you not command?

Leader. You hear the sound and see the effects. You do not steer the Spirit. New birth is God's act through the Word, not an inner impression we produce.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ezekiel 36:26–27 promises a new heart and God's Spirit, causing people to walk in His ways. How is that different from deciding to improve the old heart? **CORE**

Leader. God does not coach the dead. He gives a new heart. Obedience follows that life. It does not create it. Titus 3:5: mercy, not works done by us in righteousness.

4. Titus 3:5 says the washing of regeneration is His mercy, not works done by us in righteousness. What "works" do people still offer as the reason God made them alive?

Leader. A prayer said well, a raised hand, a moral cleanup before believing. Those may come along with the gospel. They do not cause the new birth.

5. John 3:8 says you hear the sound. What is the sound of new birth in an ordinary week?

Leader. Hunger for the Word, a conscience that tells the truth, love for Christ's people. Do not follow a feeling, and do not rank quiet stories against loud ones. Look for the life God gives.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Regeneration means God makes a dead sinner alive by the Holy Spirit. New birth is His work, not self-improvement.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Pray by name for one person still dead in sin, and do one concrete kindness for them this week. Tell them Jesus Christ makes the dead alive. New birth is God's work, not a self-improvement plan.

Leader. Get the name said in the room and written down. Next week, ask who they prayed for. The sentence names Christ. The kindness is not the new birth. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank God for making any of us alive in Christ when we were dead in sin.
2. Ask Him to give life, through the gospel, to the person you named.
3. Ask that obedience would follow the new heart, not try to earn it.

Before you stumble

Read the Part IV line: the Spirit changes us from the inside out. "Born of water and the Spirit" has been argued for centuries. Do not spend the night on baptism. If you must, one sentence: Jesus means the cleansing new birth the Spirit gives. Baptism signifies it. It does not replace the Spirit. If you are unsure, say, "We will not settle that side question tonight," and stay here: the dead must be made alive, and only God does it (John 3; Ephesians 2:1–5; Titus 3:5). Do not call a sad believer spiritually dead because they feel flat. Ask whether they trust Christ. Feelings are not the test. The Word is.

WITH STUDENTS

Nicodemus thought being an insider was enough. Ask what students trust instead of new birth: a Christian home, camp, a clean record. Then read John 3:3

again. God must make them alive.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

1 Peter 1:3 and 1:23. Born again to a living hope, through the living and abiding word of God. The Spirit uses the Word. He does not bypass it for a private voice.

Sealing



A wax seal, crest pressed in, ribbon hanging, on a written document. The seal says: this is real, this is official, this is not yours to break.

Before you gather

- Read Day 22, Sealing, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Ephesians 4:30 and 2 Corinthians 1:21–22 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What paper, key, or mark proves that something is actually yours?

Leader. Proof of ownership. The book already asked how sealing helps them feel safe, and it used Philippians 1:6. Do not repeat those. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: A seal is not a decoration. It marks ownership and says the document stands. When a sinner hears the gospel and believes, God seals him with the Holy Spirit. You are not held by your grip. You are marked as His, and He guarantees the end.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Sealing is the divine act by which the Holy Spirit marks believers as God's own possession, guarantees their future inheritance, and secures them for salvation.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek sphragizō — to seal, to mark with a sign of ownership and authenticity.

MEMORY VERSE · EPHESIANS 1:13

In him you also, when you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation, and believed in him, were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit.

Together, open the flashcard for Sealing. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Ephesians 4:30 and 2 Corinthians 1:21–22

Ephesians 1:13 is the memory verse: sealed when you heard the word of truth and believed. These two short texts show what the seal means on a bad day. Do not grieve the Spirit who sealed you. God is the One who establishes you. The seal is His guarantee, not your mood.

And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption. And it is God who establishes us with you in Christ, and has anointed us, and who has also put his seal on us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. You can grieve the Spirit. According to these verses, can you unseal yourself? What was the seal for? **CORE**

Leader. Grief is real. Sin saddens the Spirit. It does not erase the mark. You were sealed for the day of redemption. Say this clearly: do not tell an unbeliever they are already sealed. The seal follows hearing and believing.

2. Who establishes, anoints, and seals in 2 Corinthians 1? What else is the Spirit called?

Leader. God does it. The Spirit is a guarantee, a down payment of the inheritance. Assurance rests on the Sealer, not on a feeling that comes and goes.

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 1:13 puts the seal after hearing the gospel and believing. What does that order guard? What does it not mean?

Leader. It guards us from telling someone they are sealed with no faith in Christ. It does not mean the Spirit was idle before they believed. Do not build a minute-by-minute chart. Do say: the seal

belongs to believers.

4. A seal breaks only if someone stronger than the one who set it breaks it. Read John 10:28–29 beside the wax. Who would have to be overpowered for a believer to be unsealed? **CORE**

Leader. The Father, who is greater than all. No one snatches them out of His hand. Jesus came to die, and He keeps His own. Our grip is not the seal.

5. A sealed person can still grieve the Spirit. What would grieving Him look like in this group, and what would honoring the seal look like?

Leader. Lying, contempt, impurity, using people. Ephesians 4:25–32 sits next to the verse. Honoring the seal is obedience to the Word. The Spirit does not guide us by a private impression that excuses sin. We follow the Spirit, not our feelings.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Sealing means the Holy Spirit marks believers as God's own and guarantees He will bring them to the end.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Show up again for someone far from Jesus whose life will not hold still. Serve them in one plain way. Tell them that when Christ saves a person, God marks them as His and guarantees the end.

Leader. Consistency is the sermon. Do not tell them they are already sealed if they have not believed. The sentence is about what Christ does for those who trust Him. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank the Father for sealing believers with the Spirit when they believed the gospel.
2. Confess a way we have grieved Him and treated the mark as permission to sin.
3. Pray for someone who fears they have undone their salvation. Point them to Christ, not to a mood.

Before you stumble

Do not say “once saved, always saved” as if sin does not matter. Say what the text says: God seals believers for the day of redemption, and He commands them not to grieve the Spirit. Open rebellion that uses the seal as a shield needs Ephesians 4, not a soft word. A tender believer who is afraid needs John 10:28–29. Know which person you are speaking to. And do not tell an unbeliever in the room that they are already sealed. The seal follows the gospel believed.

WITH STUDENTS

A school stamp can be ignored. A king’s seal cannot. Ask which one God is like in this text, and what the day of redemption is the day He has promised.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Romans 8:9 and 8:15–16. If anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, he does not belong to Him. The Spirit bears witness, with the Word, that believers are children. Adoption is next. Do not chase an inner voice.

Adoption



A judge speaks from the bench, glad. A family gathers a child in — father, mother, son — faces up, unashamed. The law and the hug are both in the frame.

Before you gather

- Read Day 23, Adoption, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Galatians 4:4–7 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

When did someone give you a place you had not earned: a seat, a team, a name, a home?

Leader. Brought in, not earned. The book already asked about belonging, conflict in the church, and loneliness. Leave those three alone. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Adoption is not God pretending you cleaned yourself up. Jesus came to redeem those under the law. God receives believers as sons through Him, because He wanted them. A name, an inheritance, and a Father. Sons do not earn the house.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Adoption means God welcomes believers into His family as dear children, giving us full rights and love as heirs in Christ.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek huiothesia — placement as a son, the legal act of adoption.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 1:4–5

In love he predestined us for adoption to himself as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will.

Together, open the flashcard for Adoption. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Galatians 4:4–7

Galatians 4:4–7 moves a person from slave to son to heir, and puts “Abba, Father” in the mouth. That is adoption in one paragraph. It is not the journal assignment. The Son redeems. Then God receives.

But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons. And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, “Abba! Father!” So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Trace the order. What did the Son do, what do we receive, and what does the Spirit cry? **CORE**

Leader. Born of woman, born under the law, He redeems. We receive adoption as sons. The Spirit cries “Abba, Father.” Sonship follows redemption. It is not a mood we work up. Ephesians 1; Romans 8; Galatians 4.

2. In verse 7, what is the difference between a slave in the house and a son?

Leader. A slave may work the property. A son inherits it. Duty without adoption is not the gospel. God receives believers as sons through Jesus.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 8:15–17: the Spirit does not lead us back into fear, and children are heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with Him. How does adoption answer fear, and why does Paul join sonship to sharing Christ’s sufferings? **CORE**

Leader. Abba answers slave-fear. Adoption is not a promise that the family skips pain. It is a promise you do not face it as an orphan. We follow the Spirit by the Word He has given, not by a feeling that we are in the family today and out tomorrow.

4. Ephesians 1:5 says this was “according to the purpose of his will,” in love. What happens to assurance if we think we were adopted because we were the promising child?

Leader. The purpose was His. The love was His. Promising children wear themselves out trying to stay adoptable. He did not wait until we cleaned ourselves up.

5. John 1:12–13: He gave the right to become children of God to those who received Him, born not of the will of the flesh. Who near you still thinks they must earn a seat at the Father’s table?

Leader. A child, a friend, a new believer. A word of welcome must not add a condition Christ did not add. They come to Jesus. They do not clean up first.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Adoption means God receives believers as His sons and heirs through Jesus, not after they clean themselves up.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Save a real seat at your table for someone who belongs nowhere obvious. Welcome them before they earn it. Tell them God receives people as His children through Jesus, not after they clean themselves up.

Leader. One meal is enough. Welcome them. Do not turn them into a project. The sentence is the gospel of adoption, not advice to try harder at home. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank the Father that believers are sons through Jesus, not staff trying to keep a job in the house.
2. Ask Him to drive out the fear that He will put you out.
3. Pray for someone who has only known fathers as fear, that they would hear of the Father Jesus trusted.

Before you stumble

The courtroom can hurt someone whose family is not a good parable. Say this at the start: the doctrine does not depend on your earthly father being kind. God is the Father Jesus trusted, not a larger version of a wound. “Sons” in Galatians 4 is the legal standing of every believer, women and men. Daughters are not second-class. The word is the rights of the heir. Say so. Do not force a family story. Do not lead a slow, silent “Abba” exercise. Pray as children because Scripture puts that word in the church’s mouth.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a last name does on a jersey or a form. Then ask what it means that God gives His name through Jesus before we perform.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 15:22–24, the robe, the ring, and the feast. Week 2 used the embrace. Here, notice the signs of sonship given, not earned. Two minutes, if you want the picture. The Father runs. The son does not purchase the ring.

Rescue



A firefighter carries a man out of a burning room. The rescued man cannot walk himself out. The rescuer went in on purpose.

Before you gather

- Read Day 24, Rescue, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Mark 2:1–12 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

Open the room

If your house caught fire, who would you call first, and why that person?

Leader. A name, and a reason: near, able, willing. Do not ask anyone to narrate a trauma. The book already asked what God rescued them from. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Jesus does not shout instructions into a burning house. He goes in. He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us into His kingdom. Our help is not the rescue. He is.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Rescue, or deliverance, is God saving people from danger, freeing them from sin, evil, and judgment, both now and forever through Jesus.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek rhuomai — to rescue, to deliver, to draw someone out of danger.

MEMORY VERSE · COLOSSIANS 1:13

He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son.

Together, open the flashcard for Rescue. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Mark 2:1–12

Friends tear open a roof because a man cannot get himself to Jesus. Jesus forgives his sins first, then raises him. Colossians 1:13 is the memory verse: a change of kingdom,

not only a change of mood. This story shows the rescue Jesus leads with.

And they came, bringing to him a paralytic carried by four men. And when they could not get near him because of the crowd, they removed the roof above him, and when they had made an opening, they let down the bed... And when Jesus saw their faith, he said to the paralytic, "Son, your sins are forgiven." ... "But that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins" — he said to the paralytic — "I say to you, rise, pick up your bed, and go home." And he rose and immediately picked up his bed and went out before them all.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What did the friends seem to want, and what did Jesus give first? CORE

Leader. They brought a body. He said, "Son, your sins are forgiven," then told him to rise. The deepest rescue is deliverance from sin into His kingdom, not only relief from the stretcher.

2. How did the man get into the room? What does that show about his ability, and about theirs?

Leader. He was carried. Friends can bring a person toward Jesus. They cannot be the Savior. Our help is not the rescue.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Colossians 1:13 says He delivered us from a domain and transferred us into the kingdom of His beloved Son. A domain is a government. What still tries to give orders to a Christian Jesus has already moved? CORE

Leader. Shame, a habit, an old crowd, despair, the approval of people. Transfer means a new King. The old ruler does not get a spare key. Answer him with the Word, not with a feeling that you are still his.

4. Psalm 40:1–2: He drew me up from the pit and set my feet on a rock, and the psalm includes waiting. Why is waiting not the same as God failing to come?

Leader. His time and ours often differ. Waiting belongs to many deliverances. It is not proof you are still in the old kingdom. Jesus has already transferred His people.

5. The four made a hole in someone else's roof. What is a costly, practical way this group could carry someone toward Jesus without pretending to be their savior?

Leader. A ride, a meal, a seat beside you in the service, a sentence that names Christ. Costly and specific. Not "we should love people more." Our help points. Jesus delivers.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Rescue means Jesus delivers people from the domain of darkness and brings them into His kingdom.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Step into one real trouble with someone far from Jesus and help with what is actually over them. Say that Jesus delivers people from darkness into His kingdom, and that your help is not the rescue.

Leader. You are not the crisis team. If it is beyond you, help the person get real help, and stay nearby. Name Christ. Do not call your help the rescue. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank Jesus for coming into the darkness and transferring His people into His kingdom.
2. Pray by name for someone you would carry to Him if you could get them to the roof.
3. Ask Him to silence an old master that still tries to give orders.

Before you stumble

The drawing is strong, and the book speaks of real evil, including trafficking. Do not ask anyone to describe abuse, violence, or their worst day. Say: "You do not owe this room your worst day." If someone discloses harm, believe them, stop the group from fixing it in public, and follow up with real help. Deliverance is first forgiveness and a new King (Colossians 1:13). Jesus does heal bodies. Do not promise a stretcher on your timetable. Ongoing suffering is not weak faith.

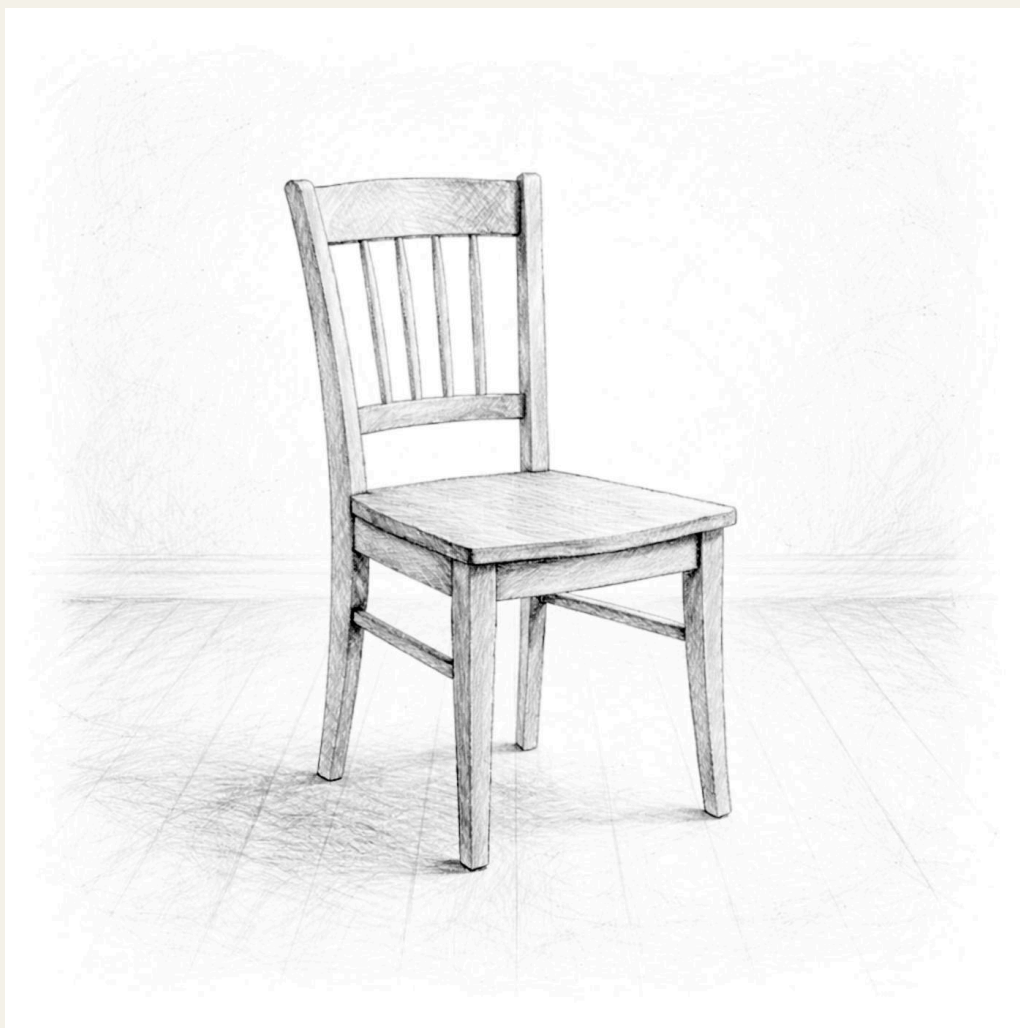
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what carrying a friend looks like when the friend does not want church. Honor courage. Forbid gossip dressed up as concern. Name Jesus. Do not play savior.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Acts 26:17–18. Jesus sends Paul to open eyes, so people turn from darkness to light and receive forgiveness. Mission is rescue under His authority. We carry. He delivers.

Faith



An empty wooden chair in a quiet room. It does not save anyone as furniture. It saves no one until a person sits and lets it hold them.

Before you gather

- Read Day 25, Faith, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Genesis 15:1–6 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Where do you hate to let someone else drive, carry the load, or hold the ladder?

Leader. Control, and the fear under it. The book already asked where they rely on works and what would deepen reliance. You are only opening the question of weight. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Faith is not standing beside the chair and agreeing that chairs are strong. Faith sits down. Trust Christ alone. He came to die as our substitute. Not trying harder. Not a vague leap. He holds the weight. Your feelings do not.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Faith is trusting Jesus alone to save you and relying on Him instead of yourself.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *pistis* — faith, trust, reliance, a confidence that rests its weight on another.

MEMORY VERSE • ROMANS 5:1

Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.

Together, open the flashcard for Faith. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Genesis 15:1–6

Abram is old and childless, and God tells him to trust a promise he cannot perform. He believed the Lord, and it was counted to him as righteousness. Romans 4 will preach

this text. Stay in the story first. Faith looks where God points.

After these things the word of the LORD came to Abram in a vision: "Fear not, Abram, I am your shield; your reward shall be very great." But Abram said, "O Lord GOD, what will you give me, for I continue childless...?" And behold, the word of the LORD came to him: "This man shall not be your heir; your very own son shall be your heir." And he brought him outside and said, "Look toward heaven, and number the stars, if you are able to number them." Then he said to him, "So shall your offspring be." And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What is Abram unable to produce, and what does God tell him to look at? CORE

Leader. An heir from his own body. The stars. God moves his eyes off himself and onto the promise. Faith is not a leap into the dark. It rests on what God has said.

2. Verse 6 is the line Paul loves. What, exactly, is counted to Abram as righteousness: a great deed, or believing the Lord?

Leader. Believing the Lord. Before circumcision, before Isaac, before the law. Trust in God's word, not trying harder.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 4:4–5 uses this story: God justifies the ungodly who do not work but believe in Him who justifies the ungodly. How is sitting in the chair different from inspecting it, praising it, or holding yourself up while you touch it? CORE

Leader. Agreement is not reliance. Many church people inspect Jesus for years. Faith puts the whole weight on Him. Not a better effort. Not a vague leap.

4. Matthew 11:28–30: "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest." Jesus offers a yoke, not a life with no Lord. How do rest and obedience fit in

the same faith?

Leader. You rest from saving yourself, and you take His yoke. Faith is not laziness about holiness. It is the end of earning, and the start of following. We follow the Spirit by the Word, not by our feelings.

5. James 2:17 says faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead. Does that cancel Romans 5:1? What is a dead “faith”, and what is a living one?

Leader. James is describing a chair nobody sits in: a claim with no trust and no fruit. Paul is describing the sitting that justifies. They are not two ways to be saved. Fruit shows the seat was taken. Do not let a debate replace that sentence.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Faith is trusting Jesus alone to save you: not trying harder, and not a vague leap.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Tell one person, in plain words, what you are trusting Christ to carry that you cannot. Ask what they are trusting. Say that faith is trust in Jesus alone, not trying harder and not a vague leap.

Leader. Plain words, not a polished speech. The action is the telling. Christ is named. Works are not the chair. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Tell God, plainly, where you are still trying to hold yourself up.
2. Thank Him that He counts faith in Christ as righteousness.
3. Ask for a living faith that rests on Jesus and then follows Him.

Before you stumble

Someone in the room may see that they have only inspected the chair. Give them a clear way, without staging a moment: turn from self-trust and trust Christ. Jesus came to die. He was our substitute. Follow up this week. Also, Abram's faith later wobbles in Genesis 16. Counted righteousness is not flawless trust every month. Say that, so a parent of a wavering child can breathe. Do not say, "Follow your feelings into faith." Say, "Believe the gospel."

WITH STUDENTS

Have them notice the chair under them, once. If they will not put weight on it, it does them no good. Make the comparison one time, cleanly, and stop. Christ holds. They do not.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 6:28–29. The work of God is to believe in the One He sent. Use it when someone asks, "What do I have to do?" The answer is not to try harder. It is to trust Christ.

Repentance



A U-turn sign beside a road that was heading the other way. Repentance is not feeling bad in the same lane. The sign is an instruction to turn around.

Before you gather

- Read Day 26, Repentance, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Luke 19:1–10 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

Open the room

When did a wrong turn cost you real time, and how long did you argue with the map before you turned around?

Leader. Delay and pride. The book already asked about godly sorrow and about easy believism. Do not rerun those two questions. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Jesus' first sermon puts two words together: repent and believe. Repentance is a real turn of mind, heart, and life, joined to faith in the gospel. It is not "be nicer." Tears in the same lane are not a U-turn.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Repentance is the turning of a sinner away from sin and toward God, involving a change of mind, heart, and direction of life.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek metanoia — a change of mind that turns the whole person.

MEMORY VERSE • MARK 1:15

The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.

Together, open the flashcard for Repentance. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Luke 19:1–10

Zacchaeus turns in public, and in his money, the same day Jesus welcomes him. You can see the U-turn. You are not opening a confession circle. Jesus seeks. The sinner

turns.

He entered Jericho and was passing through. And behold, there was a man named Zacchaeus. He was a chief tax collector and rich. ... And when Jesus came to the place, he looked up and said to him, "Zacchaeus, hurry and come down, for I must stay at your house today." ... And Zacchaeus stood and said to the Lord, "Behold, Lord, the half of my goods I give to the poor. And if I have defrauded anyone of anything, I restore it fourfold." And Jesus said to him, "Today salvation has come to this house... For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Who moves first: Zacchaeus climbing, or Jesus calling? What does Zacchaeus do after Jesus comes to the house? **CORE**

Leader. Jesus seeks and calls. Zacchaeus answers with joy and a costly turn: he gives, and he pays back what he stole. Repentance responds to the Seeker. It does not earn the visit. It is not a self-help project.

2. Jesus calls this salvation, and He calls Zacchaeus lost in the same breath, though he is a son of Abraham. Lost from what, if he was already near Israel's religion?

Leader. Lost is not only "far from church." A wealthy insider can be lost. Salvation comes to the house. The issue was not manners. It was direction, and it was Christ.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Mark 1:15 will not split repent from believe. What does a so-called faith look like with no U-turn, and what does a turn look like with no gospel to turn toward? **CORE**

Leader. Faith with no turn is an empty claim. A turn with no gospel is moralism, or despair. "Be nicer" is neither repentance nor faith. Jesus holds the two together.

4. Acts 3:19: repent and turn, that sins may be blotted out. Acts 26:20: deeds in keeping with repentance. Why is paying people back, when you can, part of the turn, and not a way of paying Jesus back?

Leader. Zacchaeus does not purchase salvation. The welcome came first. The money shows the turn is real. Jesus was our substitute. Where payback is impossible, the turn still shows: confess the sin, and change direction.

5. You do not have to name a sin out loud in this circle. What is the shape of a real turn, a change of direction and not only a regret, that you already know?

Leader. Shape, not a performance: a habit stopped, a person repaid, a lie corrected, a relationship met differently. Do not go around the circle demanding stories. A quiet room is not the method. The method is the Word: repent and believe the gospel.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Repentance is a real turn of mind, heart, and life away from sin and toward God, joined to faith in the gospel.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Turn from one pattern someone far from Jesus has watched in you. Tell them you are turning because of Christ. Say repentance is a real change of mind, heart, and life, joined to faith in Him, not “be nicer.”

Leader. Help them name the pattern before they leave. “Be nicer” is not a turn. The sentence must join the turn to Jesus. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank Jesus that He seeks the lost and does not wait to be impressed.
2. Ask for a real turn where you have only felt sorry and stayed in the same lane.
3. Pray for a house, like Zacchaeus’s, where salvation still needs to arrive through the gospel.

Before you stumble

Do not turn the group into a confession booth, and do not embarrass anyone. If someone confesses something serious, receive it briefly, thank them, and take the rest offline with care. Repentance is not penance. You do not assign spiritual punishments. It is also not nothing. Easy agreement with no new direction is not Mark 1:15. Hold both, without a debate-club tone. The call is simple: turn, and trust Christ.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a U-turn looks like on a phone: who they stop texting, what they stop watching, who they tell the truth to. Specific beats a mood. “Be nicer” is not repentance.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

2 Corinthians 7:8–10, only if someone asks whether sorrow counts. Godly grief produces a turn. Worldly grief is regret with no change of road. They may have read this in the book. Use it to clarify, not as the main text.

Sanctification



A man pulls a clean robe over a stained shirt, and he is glad to do it. He is not hiding. He is dressing for a new identity that is already his.

Before you gather

- Read Day 27, Sanctification, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Colossians 3:1–4, 12–14 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

Open the room

What jacket, uniform, or jersey changed how you carried yourself the day you put it on?

Leader. An identity you wear. The book already asked them to define positional and progressive sanctification, and to list sins to take off. Do not quiz the journal. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Sanctification is not a costume and not the same gift as justification. God has already set His people apart: washed, sanctified, justified. And He is making them like Christ. Already His. Not yet finished. God gave the growth. We obey.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Sanctification means God has set you apart as holy and His, and now He is making you more like Jesus.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek hagiasmos — holiness, consecration, being set apart as God's.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 CORINTHIANS 6:11

And such were some of you. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.

Together, open the flashcard for Sanctification. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Colossians 3:1–4, 12–14

Paul begins with “you have been raised with Christ,” then tells them what to put on. The order is the doctrine. Commands land on people who already belong to God. Holiness here is how they treat one another, not a private mood.

If then you have been raised with Christ, seek the things that are above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things that are above, not on things that are on earth. For you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God. When Christ who is your life appears, then you also will appear with him in glory. Put on then, as God’s chosen ones, holy and beloved, compassionate hearts, kindness, humility, meekness, and patience, bearing with one another... And above all these put on love, which binds everything together in perfect harmony.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What does Paul say is already true of them before he tells them to put anything on?

CORE

Leader. Raised with Christ. Died with Him. Life hidden with Christ. Chosen, holy, and beloved. The command comes to people God has already set apart. He is not waiting to see if He likes them.

2. Look at the list in verses 12–14. Are these mostly private feelings, or ways of treating other people?

Leader. Mostly ways of treating people: compassion, kindness, humility, meekness, patience, bearing with one another, love. Holiness shows up in the room. We follow the Spirit by obeying this Word, not by chasing a feeling of being holy.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 Corinthians 6:11 puts washed, sanctified, and justified in the past tense: “such were some of you.” How should a Christian speak about the past: as if it never happened, or as if it is no longer in charge? CORE

Leader. Paul names the old life, then says “were.” Tell the truth. Do not let the old life keep the name. Justification is the verdict. Sanctification, in this verse, is the new standing. They are distinct. Both are God’s. Neither is our polish.

4. Philippians 2:12–13: work out your salvation, for it is God who works in you to will and to work. Where do we slide into “God does it, so I will not” or “I do it, so it depends on me”?

Leader. Both slides deny the verse. We work because He works. Effort is not earning. Sitting still is not faith. God gave the growth. We obey.

5. Colossians 3:4 says Christ is your life, and that you will appear with Him in glory. What would change this month if holiness meant becoming who you already are in Him, not becoming someone God might finally accept?

Leader. Fear-based change wears people out. You are already His. You are not finished. That is sanctification, and it is not justification. You can tie it to adoption without reteaching the whole doctrine.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Sanctification means God has set His people apart as His, and He is making them like Jesus: already His, not yet finished.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Let someone who does not follow Jesus see you still being changed. Apologize where you were wrong, and serve them. Tell them God has set His people apart in Christ and is making them like Jesus. Already His. Not finished.

Leader. An honest unfinished place will say more than a victory speech. Name Christ. Do not confuse sanctification with earning justification. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank God that “holy and beloved” is already what He calls His people in Christ.
2. Ask for one virtue from Colossians 3, and name it, to be put on this week toward a real person.
3. Ask Him to keep working in you, so your effort is obedience and not panic.

Before you stumble

Two errors meet at the end of Part IV. One hears “already holy” and stops fighting sin. One hears “become holy” and lives condemned. First Corinthians 6:11 will not hold either. Progress is real and uneven. Do not promise a new personality by next month. Do not call a sin this passage tells you to put away “just your wiring.” If you need the put-off list, read Colossians 3:5–9. Do not make people share it. Keep the distinction: justification declares the believer righteous in Christ.

Sanctification sets him apart and makes him like Christ. Already His. Not yet finished.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what team gear does to how they play. Then ask what it means to practice as someone already on the roster in Christ, not as someone auditioning for God’s favor every day.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Romans 6:11–14, if they want the fight stated plainly: count yourselves dead to sin and alive to God, and do not let sin reign. Hebrews 10:14 holds both sides: He has perfected for all time those who are being sanctified. Distinct from the verdict, and not yet the finish.

Hope



An anchor on the seafloor, chain rising into the light. The holding place is not the sailor's mood. The flukes are in something solid, out of sight.

OPEN PART V BY SAYING

Hope, glory, and God's choice before the world began. We teach election last so the room hears it as comfort, not as a puzzle. God chose a people in Christ. Whoever comes to Jesus, He will never cast out.

Before you gather

- Read Day 28, Hope, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Hebrews 6:17–20 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day’s reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

Name something you are confident will happen, not something you merely wish would happen.

Leader. Confidence versus a wish. The book already asked how trials show where hope lies, and it used Ephesians 1. Do not reopen those. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Biblical hope is not “I hope so.” It is a confident expectation. The anchor goes behind the curtain, into God’s presence, because Jesus the risen Christ has already gone in. The chain holds when your mood does not.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Hope is the confident expectation of future good, grounded in the promises of God and secured by the finished work of Jesus Christ.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *elpis* — confident expectation, not a wish.

MEMORY VERSE · HEBREWS 6:19

We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul, a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain.

Together, open the flashcard for Hope. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Hebrews 6:17–20

Read the memory verse inside its paragraph. The anchor is God's oath and Jesus our forerunner, not a technique for sad people. Hope is tied to a promise God cannot break.

So when God desired to show more convincingly to the heirs of the promise the unchangeable character of his purpose, he guaranteed it with an oath, so that by two unchangeable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who have fled for refuge might have strong encouragement to hold fast to the hope set before us. We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul, a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain, where Jesus has gone as a forerunner on our behalf.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What two unchangeable things make this hope strong, and where does the anchor actually go? CORE

Leader. God's promise and God's oath. It is impossible for God to lie. The anchor enters behind the curtain, where Jesus has gone as a forerunner. Hope is fastened to the risen Christ in God's presence, not to a feeling.

2. Verse 18: who is this strong encouragement for, and what had they done?

Leader. Heirs of the promise who have fled for refuge. Hope belongs to people who needed somewhere to run, not to people who have life under control.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Read Romans 8:23–25. Paul says we hope for what we do not see, and we wait for it with patience. How is that different from pretending this week is fine? CORE

Leader. Christian hope tells the truth about groaning and still expects the redemption of our bodies. It is not denial. It is not a wish. It is confidence in what God has promised.

4. 1 Peter 1:3–4 ties a living hope to the resurrection of Jesus Christ and to an inheritance that does not fade, kept in heaven. What are you hoping in that can spoil or be taken, and what cannot?

Leader. Health, money, a political result, a child's success, even a ministry. Name them without shaming. Those are not the anchor. The risen Christ, and the inheritance God keeps, cannot be taken.

5. The flukes of the anchor are out of sight. What does it look like, this week, to hold fast to a hope you cannot see?

Leader. Pray God's promise back to Him. Stay with the saints. Open the Word again. Refuse a smaller god. Not a smile you put on for the group. We follow the Spirit by the Word, not by how hopeful we feel.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Hope is a confident expectation of future good, grounded in God's promise and in the risen Christ, not a wish.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Sit with someone who is afraid of what is coming, and carry one concrete load for them. Tell them hope in Christ is not a wish. It is confidence in the risen Jesus and in promises God keeps.

Leader. Do not correct their grief. Carry something. Then speak. The sentence names the risen Christ. It is not “things will work out.” Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank God that He cannot lie, and that Jesus has already gone in ahead of His people.
2. Name one groan you will not pretend is fine, and set it beside His promise.
3. Ask for a hope strong enough to wait, without grabbing a smaller anchor.

Before you stumble

Part V begins: the story is going somewhere. Do not explain someone’s suffering as a lesson they should have learned faster. Hebrews was written to people in danger of drifting, not to people who needed a scolding. If someone is in real despair, the anchor is Jesus the forerunner, not their ability to feel hopeful before they leave. Stay after if you need to. Do not prescribe silence as the cure. Put a promise in their hands.

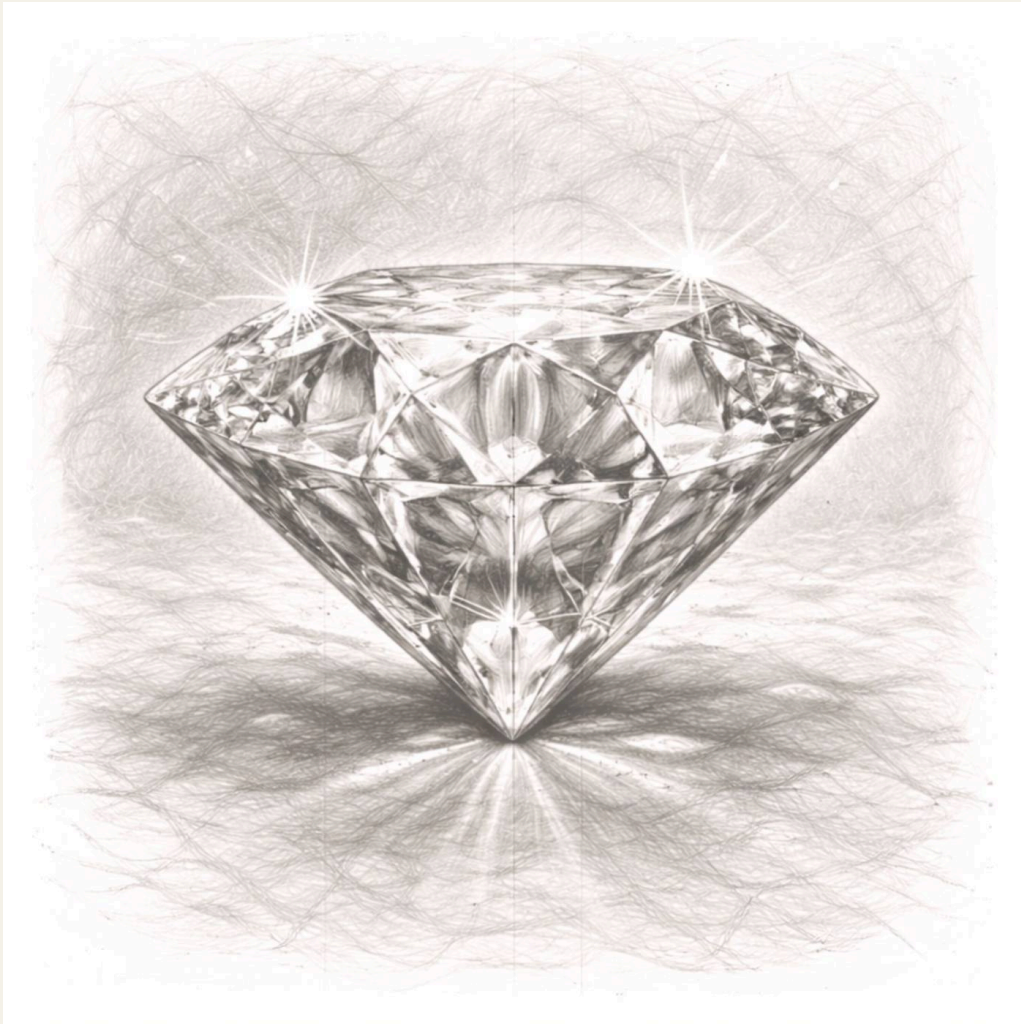
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what they mean when they say “hopefully.” Then ask what Hebrews requires before that word is Christian hope. The bar is God’s oath and the risen Christ, not their optimism.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Romans 15:13, if the night was heavy. The God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, by the power of the Holy Spirit. And 1 Peter 3:15: be ready to give a reason for the hope that is in you. The reason is Christ, not a mood.

Glorification



A diamond throws light it did not invent. Pressure, cut, and clarity turn a stone into something that shines. Glory, in the drawing, is reflected light.

Before you gather

- Read Day 29, Glorification, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read 1 John 3:2 and Revelation 21:3–5 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

Open the room

What ordinary thing have you seen turn brilliant when the light hit it right?

Leader. Reflected light, not a list of hardships. The book already asked what they want to leave behind, and it used Philippians 3:20. Do not retake that list. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Glorification is not our glow-up. When Christ appears, believers will be made like Him, body and soul. The diamond does not invent the light. It answers it. No one in Christ is finished being discarded.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Glorification is the wonderful moment when Jesus returns and God instantly makes every Christian completely perfect, like Jesus Himself, with no more sin, pain, weakness, or death, so we can live with Him forever in glory.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek doxa — glory, weight, honor, splendor.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 CORINTHIANS 15:42–43

So is it with the resurrection of the dead. What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power.

Together, open the flashcard for Glorification. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

1 John 3:2 and Revelation 21:3–5

First John 3:2 aims the hope at seeing Jesus and being made like Him. Revelation 21 aims it at God dwelling with His people and making all things new. Together they keep glorification from shrinking into a better body with the same old center.

Beloved, we are God's children now, and what we will be has not yet appeared; but we know that when he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is. And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, "Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God. He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away." And he who was seated on the throne said, "Behold, I am making all things new."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What do we already know, and what has not yet appeared? What does John say we will be, and why? **CORE**

Leader. We are God's children now. What we will be has not appeared. We shall be like Him, because we shall see Him as He is. The sight of Christ finishes the likeness, body and soul. That is promise, not a guess.

2. In Revelation 21, what is the center of the new world: the absence of pain, or the presence of God? What happens to death, mourning, and pain, and who does it?

Leader. God with His people is the center. He wipes away every tear. Do not let "no more pain" replace "God himself will be with them," even though we reach for the pain line first.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 8:30 puts glorified in the past tense, in the same chain as called and justified. Why does Paul speak of a future resurrection as if it were already settled?

CORE

Leader. Because the God who began the chain does not drop the last link. For those He called, glorification is as certain as justification. It is promise, not a wish. He will finish what He started.

4. 1 Corinthians 15:42–43 sets perishable against imperishable, dishonor against glory, weakness against power. Which contrast do you feel most in your body, or in the fight with sin?

Leader. Let them answer in a sentence. Then say: the raising is God's, at Christ's appearing, and it is complete. It is not a long climb into glory. That slow obedience is sanctification. This is the finish. No one in Christ is finished being discarded.

5. 1 John 3:3 says everyone who thus hopes in Him purifies himself as He is pure. How does a future likeness produce present cleanness, instead of the attitude "nothing matters until then"?

Leader. You practice now what you are sure you will be. The hope of glory fuels holiness. It is not a reason to quit. Week 27 and this week belong in one story: already His, and not yet finished, until He appears.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Glorification means that when Christ appears, God will make every believer like Jesus, body and soul, forever.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Visit someone the world treats as finished who does not know Jesus, and help with something physical. Tell them that when Christ appears, He will make His people like Himself, body and soul. No one in Him is discarded.

Leader. The visit is required. A verse in a text is not the challenge. Say Christ. Do not promise glory to someone who has not come to Him. Invite them. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank God that what we will be has not yet appeared, and that He has already settled the end in Christ.
2. Ask that the hope of being like Jesus would purify one present habit.
3. Pray for someone weary in a body that is wearing out, that they would hear of Christ and the resurrection.

Before you stumble

Do not describe glory in detail the text does not give. We know more about who we will be with than about the furniture. Do not shame the sick or the old for wanting pain to end. Revelation includes that, under the greater promise: God with us. Glorification is for those in Christ, not an upgrade for decent people. Say that kindly if the room widens it. And say this: no one in Christ is finished being discarded. When He appears, He will raise them, body and soul.

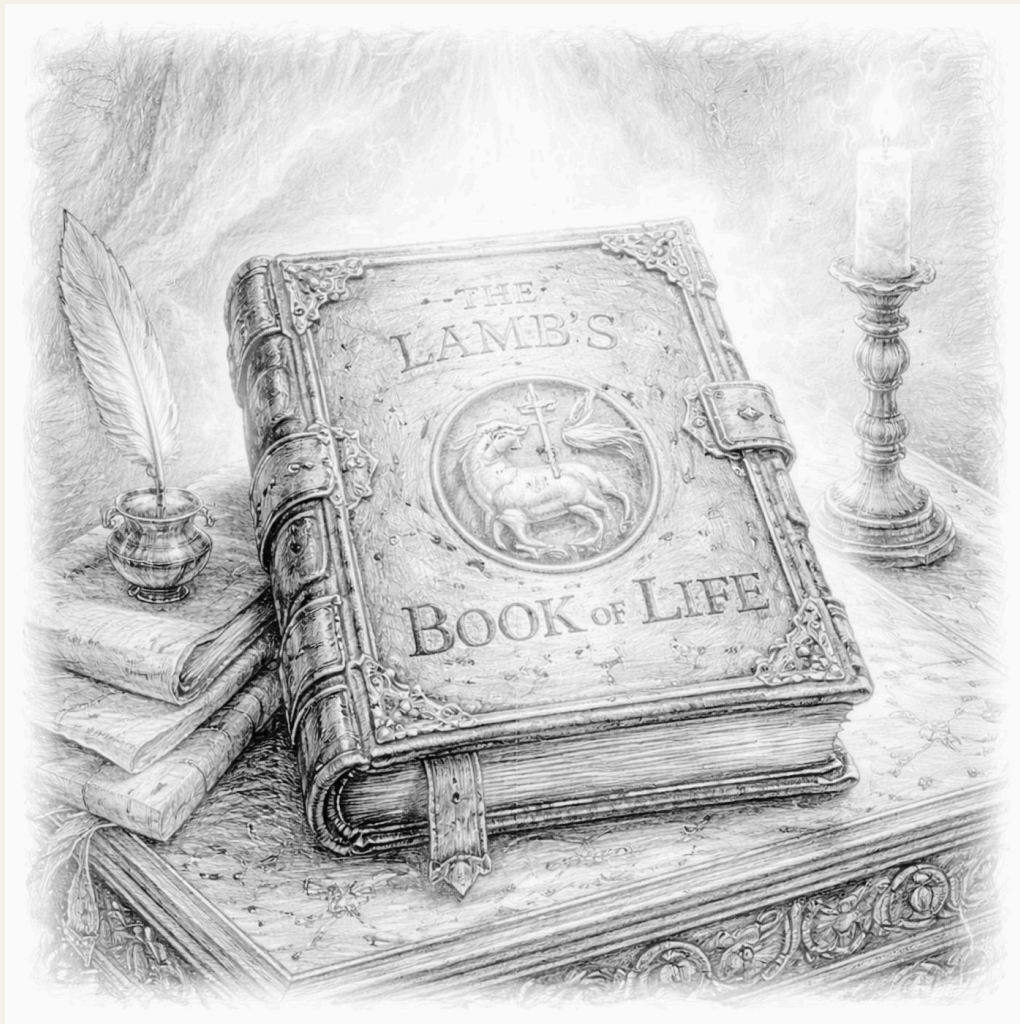
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what they think “perfect” will feel like. Then read, “we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is.” The center is Jesus, not an upgraded self.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Philippians 3:20–21, only as a closing reading if you have two minutes. They reflected on it already. Let it bless the room, not reteach the week: He will transform our lowly body to be like His glorious body.

Election



The Lamb's Book of Life, shut with a clasp, a quill and a candle beside it. Names in a book the readers did not write. Light falls on the cover.

Before you gather

- Read Day 30, Election, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Deuteronomy 7:6–8 and Romans 8:29–30 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What story do you love in which, by the end, you see the ending was prepared from the first page?

Leader. A prepared ending. The book already asked about peace in storms, and about names not erased in Revelation 3:5. Leave both alone. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Election means God chose a people in Christ before the foundation of the world, in love, to be holy. Not because we were better. The book in the drawing is the Lamb's book. We did not write the names. That is why this story was never fragile.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Election is God's choice, made before the world began, to save people through Jesus, not because they earned it or were better than others, but because of His love and mercy.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek eklegomai — to choose, to pick out, to call one's own.

MEMORY VERSE · EPHESIANS 1:3–4

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly

places, even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him.

Together, open the flashcard for Election. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Deuteronomy 7:6–8 and Romans 8:29–30

Deuteronomy 7 tells Israel they were not chosen for being impressive. Romans 8:29–30 walks the chain from foreknowledge to glory. Use it to look back over thirty weeks. Do not turn the night into a debate, and do not retake a final exam.

For you are a people holy to the LORD your God. The LORD your God has chosen you to be a people for his treasured possession, out of all the peoples who are on the face of the earth. It was not because you were more in number than any other people that the LORD set his love on you and chose you, for you were the fewest of all peoples, but it is because the LORD loves you and is keeping the oath that he swore to your fathers. For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son... And those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In Deuteronomy 7, what reason for His choice does God refuse, and what reason does He give? **CORE**

Leader. Not because they were more in number. Because the Lord loves them and keeps the oath He swore. Election empties boasting. Ephesians 1:4–5: chosen in Christ, in love, before the foundation of the world, not because we were better.

2. Walk Romans 8:29–30 slowly. Which words from these thirty weeks do you hear inside that chain?

Leader. Foreknown, predestined, conformed to the image of His Son, called, justified, glorified. Let them connect what they have learned. Do not force every word to fit. Christ holds the chain. God gave the growth, and He will finish it.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 1:4 says He chose us in Him, in Christ, that we should be holy. How does “in Christ” keep election from becoming either pride or paralysis? **CORE**

Leader. Pride says, “I was the better one.” Paralysis says, “I cannot know, so I will not come.” Look at Christ, not at a secret list in your head. We were not chosen because a future faith made us attractive, or because we were better. We are chosen in Him.

4. John 6:37: “All that the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I will never cast out.” What does the second half do to the fear that election locks the door on someone who wants in?

Leader. The rule of the door is this: whoever comes to Jesus, He will never cast out. Election explains why anyone comes. It is not a guard against the willing. Say it clearly. This is the pastoral center of the night. Do not open a debate.

5. You have thirty words. Using any five, with no notes for a moment, how would you tell a friend what God has done in Jesus? One minute. Clumsy is fine.

Leader. This sends them. Listen. Encourage. Add only what they dropped if it was the cross, or the call to repent and believe. Do not grade vocabulary. If the group is large, use pairs. The sentence has to name Christ.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Election is God’s choice, before the world began, to save a people in Christ, out of love, not because they were better.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Go to the person you would have skipped, the one easy to forget. Pray for them, serve them, and invite them to Christ. Say His welcome out loud: whoever comes to Jesus, He will never cast out.

Leader. Do not explain election on the porch. Election is why you go to the person you would have skipped. Keep John 6:37 in your mouth, and name Christ. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Bless the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, in the words of Ephesians 1:3–5 if you can.
2. Thank Him that He chose a people in love, in Christ, not because they were better.
3. Ask for courage to say the gospel in ordinary words this week, and pray for one name.

Before you stumble

This word has split rooms. Your job is not to win a system, and not to host a debate. Say what these texts say. Refuse what they do not. They do not say God is cruel, or that He delights in rejecting people. They do not say we were chosen because we were better, or because a future faith made us attractive. They do

say love, Christ, holiness, and a real human coming to Jesus. If someone is angry, do not mock them. Give them John 6:37. If someone is proud, Deuteronomy 7 is the cure. If someone fears they are not chosen, the test is not a feeling about eternity past. The test is whether they will come to Christ. Whoever comes, He will never cast out. End the thirty weeks with praise, not an argument. A last line you can use: the Lamb's book is His, the blood is His, the welcome is His, and it is open to all who come.

WITH STUDENTS

Skip the debate labels. Ask: if God loved you for being ahead of the class, what happens when you fall behind? Then read Deuteronomy 7:7–8 in words they can hear. He did not pick you for being more. He loves you, and He chose a people in Christ.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Revelation 21:27 beside John 6:37. Only those written in the Lamb's book of life enter the city. And whoever comes to Jesus, He will never cast out. Leave both in their hands: a real book, and a real welcome. Then go.